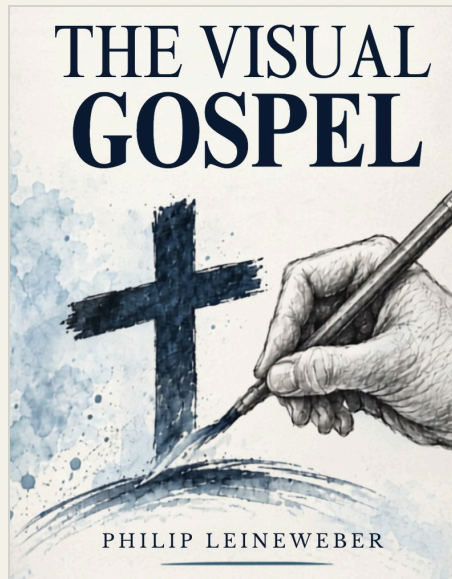


PHILIP LEINEWEBER



The Visual Gospel

Leader Guide

A 30-week study for small groups, classes, youth, and families. To be used alongside the devotional and the flashcard app — not instead of them.



Purchase the devotional

visualgospelbook.com

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About this guide

The Visual Gospel Leader Guide is a free companion to The Visual Gospel by Philip Leineweber (ISBN 979-8-1943079-3-7). Definitions and memory verses are taken from the book. The icebreakers, passages, and discussion questions were written for the gathering. They are not the reflection questions, gospel responses, or prayers printed in the devotion. Those belong to the personal reading.

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The drawings are the studies created for The Visual Gospel. Week numbers follow the book.

How to lead the hour

Plan on 60 to 75 minutes. The book is a 30-day devotion. This guide is 30 gatherings — one word a week. Everyone should already have read that day and sat with its reflection questions. If they have not, still use this guide. Do not switch back to the journal prompts. Those were for the quiet hour. These are for the room.

The shape of a strong hour

The rhythm is borrowed from three guides that already work in real rooms. The Gospel-Centered Life moves from the text to the heart and will not let application outrun Christ. Knowing the Bible makes a group say what a passage actually says before anyone applies it. Gospel in Life opens with a human question, stays in Scripture, and ends in prayer instead of homework that repeats the reading. This guide assumes the reading is done. The hour is a new passage, and a conversation.

1 · 7 MIN

Icebreaker

A light question tied to the picture. People may pass.

2 · 8 MIN

The word

Look at the drawing, read the definition, say the memory verse, open the card.

3 · 15 MIN

Open the Bible

A passage they did not already journal. Read it aloud. Ask what it says.

4 · 20 MIN

Around the room

Three new questions. Stay curious. Do not reteach the devotion.

5 · 5 MIN

Say it

Two volunteers put the word into one sentence a friend could understand.

6 · 8 MIN

Pray

Three prompts. Leave silence. Do not reread the book's prayer.

Before you walk in

- Read the day in The Visual Gospel yourself. Do not summarize the essay back to people who read it.
- Read the gathering's passage in your own Bible. The excerpt in the guide is a backup, not a replacement.
- Skim "Before you stumble." The hard weeks — wrath, depravity, propitiation, election — have a line you can say without starting a debate.
- Have the drawing ready: the book, a printed page, or a screen. Have Bibles in the room. Phones are for the card, then they go down.

How to ask

Ask the question, then wait. Eight seconds feels long and is not long enough. When an answer is fuzzy, ask "Where do you see that in the passage?" instead of giving a speech. If someone answers the journal question from the book, thank them and return to the question in front of you. You are a facilitator. The text teaches.

Questions marked **Core** are the ones to keep if you only have 45 minutes: one voice on the icebreaker, the verse said together, the passage read aloud, the Core questions, and a short prayer.

The picture and the cards

Show the drawing and give the room ten quiet seconds. Then use the short script under the picture if you need words. After that, open cards.visualgospelbook.com, find the week's word, and say the word, the definition, and the verse together once. Review two older cards if you are past week four and the room is willing. Then close it.

Students, families, and a shorter night

With students, use the icebreaker, the picture, the verse, and the line marked for youth in the leader notes. Drop the second "from the passage" question if energy falls. At a

family table, read the passage, ask one Core question, and pray the first prompt. Nobody needs all six movements to have met with God.

A note on the hard words

Wrath is not God losing His temper. Depravity means we cannot save ourselves, not that every person is as bad as possible or that their sadness is spiritual death.

Propitiation means wrath landed on Christ, and it is received by faith — do not tell a room that everyone is already safe, and do not shrink the cross to your circle.

Justification is a declaration, not the slow work of sanctification. Election, in week 30, is taught after the welcome of Christ is clear: whoever comes to Him, He will never cast out. The leader notes say this again where it matters. Read them. Do not read them aloud.

Thirty weeks

PART I · GOD'S HEART

1	Creation	Genesis 1:26–27
2	Love	John 3:16
3	Mercy	1 Peter 1:3
4	Grace	Ephesians 2:8–9

PART II · OUR PROBLEM

5	Sin	Romans 3:23
6	Depravity	Ephesians 2:1–2
7	Wrath	Romans 1:18
8	Judgment	Hebrews 9:27
9	Condemnation	John 3:18

PART III · CHRIST'S WORK

10	Incarnation	John 1:14
11	Gospel	Luke 2:10–11
12	Salvation	Romans 1:16
13	Atonement	1 Peter 2:24
14	Propitiation	1 John 2:2
15	Justification	Romans 3:24
16	Mediation	1 Timothy 2:5–6
17	Redemption	Ephesians 1:7
18	Reconciliation	Colossians 1:19–20
19	Forgiveness	Colossians 1:14

20	Covenant	Hebrews 9:15
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PART IV · THE SPIRIT'S ROLE

21	Regeneration	Titus 3:5
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22	Sealing	Ephesians 1:13
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23	Adoption	Ephesians 1:4–5
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24	Rescue	Colossians 1:13
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25	Faith	Romans 5:1
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26	Repentance	Mark 1:15
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27	Sanctification	1 Corinthians 6:11
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PART V · OUR FUTURE

28	Hope	Hebrews 6:19
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29	Glorification	1 Corinthians 15:42–43
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30	Election	Ephesians 1:3–4
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Creation



Two hands reach across empty space and do not quite meet. Nearness was the design. The gap is not the design.

OPEN PART I BY SAYING

For four weeks, do not start with the problem. Start with God. Creation, love, mercy, and grace are not warm-up acts for the gospel. They are the God of the gospel. If the room wants to rush to the cross, let them feel the wait.

Before you gather

- Read Day 1, Creation, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Psalm 8:3–6 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

When you were ten, what did you think a good life was for? A job, a team, making someone proud, being left alone?

Leader. Get ordinary answers. You will contrast them with “for God” later. Do not correct anyone yet. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Give the room ten quiet seconds with the drawing. Then say: These hands were meant to meet. We were made for God, not merely made by God. The gospel starts there, in a garden, before it starts with our failure.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Creation is God making the whole world and everything in it. He made people in a special way so we could know, love, and reflect Him.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Hebrew *asah* — to fashion, accomplish, or produce. Greek *poieō* — to make, to create, to do.

MEMORY VERSE • GENESIS 1:26–27

Then God said, “Let us make man in our image, after our likeness.” So God created man in his own image, in the image of God he created him; male and female he created them.

Together, open the flashcard for Creation. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 · OPEN THE BIBLE · 15 MIN

Psalm 8:3–6

The memory work is Genesis 1. Psalm 8 looks at the same truth from underneath the night sky: people are small, and yet crowned. Stay in this psalm. Do not reteach the garden essay.

When I look at your heavens, the work of your fingers, the moon and the stars, which you have set in place, what is man that you are mindful of him, and the son of man that you care for him? Yet you have made him a little lower than the heavenly beings and crowned him with glory and honor. You have given him dominion over the works of your hands; you have put all things under his feet.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. In these verses, what belongs to God alone, and what is handed to human beings?

CORE

Leader. God made the heavens. People receive mind, care, a crown, and a task. Dignity is given, not seized.

2. The writer is looking at the sky while he says this. What kind of prayer is this — a boast, a question, or both?

Leader. It is wonder. Creation theology that never becomes worship has missed the psalm.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Colossians 1:16 says all things were made through the Son and for Him. If the gospel is God's story before it is our rescue story, what has to change in the way we usually explain Jesus?

Leader. Listen for answers that still put us at the center. Gently move the subject from "what I get" to "who He is."

4. Genesis 3:15 is the first promise that the Creator will not abandon what He made. Why is that promise already gospel, even though no one in the story has been to a cross yet? CORE

Leader. The rescue was promised in the same chapter as the ruin. Creation and redemption are one story.

5. Isaiah 43:6–7 says God formed a people for His glory. Where do the people in our town go looking for a glory that creatures were never meant to carry?

Leader. Keep it local: work, kids' sports, romance, reputation, ministry success. No need for personal confession yet.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

You were made by God and for God, and the gospel is how He remakes what sin broke.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Thank God as Maker — of the room you are in, and of the people in it.
2. Confess the ways we treat ourselves as the center of the story.

3. Ask for eyes to see the person beside you as image-bearing handiwork, not as a problem to manage.

Before you stumble

Resist skipping straight to “and then we sinned.” Sit in the goodness for a few minutes. The bad news will land harder in Part II because you did.

WITH STUDENTS

Ask which feels harder to believe: that they are small, or that they are crowned. Most students feel one of those and not the other.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

John 1:1–5. The Word who made all things is the Word who will take on flesh. If you have five extra minutes, read it and stop. Do not preview the whole study.

Love



A father pulls a child in and will not let the embrace be polite. Faces close, arms locked. This is love with a body.

Before you gather

- Read Day 2, Love, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Hosea 11:1–4, 8–9 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

Open the room

What is a small, specific way someone loved you this month that you did not have to earn?

Leader. Concrete and recent. If answers stay abstract (“my family loves me”), ask: “What did they actually do?” Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: We use the word love for food, teams, and moods. The drawing refuses that. Love here is a father who closes the distance. God’s love is His decision to give His Son for people who were not lovely.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Love is God choosing to give of Himself for our good. It is God’s faithful commitment to rescue and restore. It is seen most clearly in God sending His Son, Jesus, to save sinners.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek *agapē* — to love, to delight in, to be well-pleased with.

MEMORY VERSE • JOHN 3:16

For God so loved the world, that he gave his only Son, that whoever believes in him should not perish but have eternal life.

Together, open the flashcard for Love. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

Hosea 11:1–4, 8–9

The devotion already walked the lost son and John 15:13. Hosea shows the same love from God's side of a badly failed relationship: a parent who will not hand the child over.

When Israel was a child, I loved him, and out of Egypt I called my son. The more they were called, the more they went away... Yet it was I who taught Ephraim to walk; I took them up by their arms... I led them with cords of kindness, with the bands of love. How can I give you up, O Ephraim? My heart recoils within me; my compassion grows warm and tender. I will not execute my burning anger... for I am God and not a man, the Holy One in your midst.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. What has the child done in this passage, and what does the Father refuse to do?

CORE

Leader. The child ran. The Father will not give him up. Love is action against a real offense, not a compliment.

2. Verse 9 says, "I am God and not a man." How is His love different from the way people usually love when they are hurt?

Leader. Human love often withdraws or pays back. His love stays holy and stays near.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Romans 5:8 says God shows His love "while we were still sinners," not after we improved. How is that a different order from almost every relationship we know? CORE

Leader. We love the responsive. He loves the hostile. Let the room feel the reversal.

4. John 13:1 says Jesus loved His own "to the end," in the hour they were about to fail Him. What does love look like when you already know the other person will let you down?

Leader. This is not romance. It is covenant stickiness. Connect it to parents, friends, and the church.

5. If God's love is a commitment to rescue and not a mood, where are we tempted to measure it by how this month feels?

Leader. Suffering, silence, unanswered prayer. Do not explain their pain away. Point them back to the cross as the proof, not to their week.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

God's love is God giving Himself for our good, and the clearest place we see it is Jesus on the cross.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Praise God for a love that does not wait for us to be worth it.
2. Name, silently, someone you have loved only when they were easy.
3. Ask for that person to meet the Father Hosea describes, and for this group to love more like Him.

Before you stumble

Do not let "God is love" cancel holiness. This part of the study is God's heart, and wrath is coming in week 7 on purpose. If someone says love means God is never angry, say: "Hold that. A love that makes peace with evil is not the love of Hosea 11."

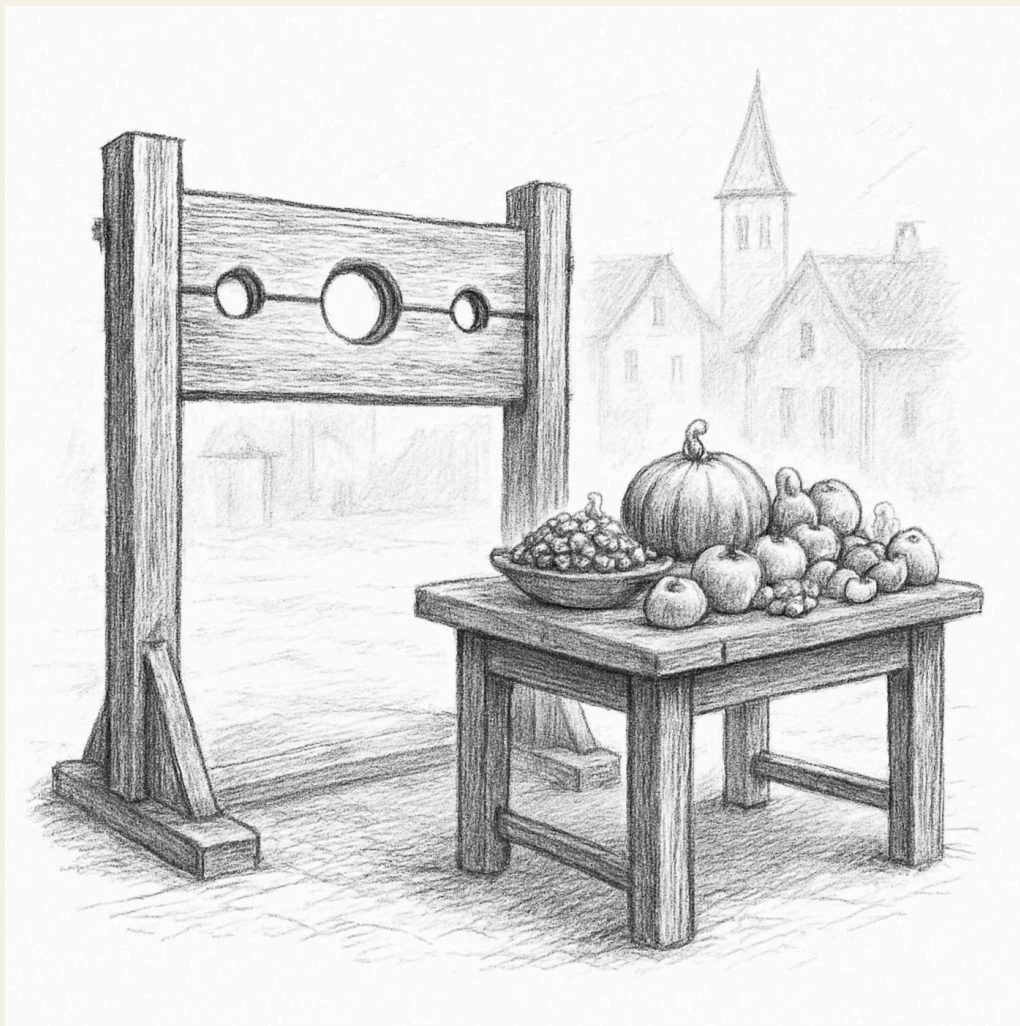
WITH STUDENTS

Students often hear “love” as approval. Ask: “Does this Father approve of the running, or does He refuse to abandon the runner?” Those are different.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Zephaniah 3:17. God quiets His people with His love. Read it as a benediction if the conversation has been heavy.

Mercy



A town stock is ready for a guilty person. Beside it, the table holds good fruit, not rotten produce to throw. The sentence was real. The gift is real too.

Before you gather

- Read Day 3, Mercy, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Jonah 4:1–2, 10–11 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

Open the room

Tell about a time you braced for a consequence and got kindness instead. One sentence. You can pass.

Leader. Keep it light and short. The devotion already asked about “radical mercy” in depth. Do not turn the icebreaker into that journal question. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: In that square, everyone knows what the guilty person deserves. Mercy does not pretend the stocks were a joke. Mercy withholds the punishment and sets a feast where the rotten fruit would have been.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Mercy is God’s compassionate withholding of deserved judgment and His tender action toward helpless sinners. It is God’s desire to relieve the consequences of sin in those who deserve condemnation through Christ’s sacrifice.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek eleos — mercy, kindness, goodwill toward the afflicted.

MEMORY VERSE · 1 PETER 1:3

Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ! According to his great mercy, he has caused us to be born again to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead.

Together, open the flashcard for Mercy. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

Jonah 4:1–2, 10–11

Jonah is not in the day's reflection questions. He is angry that God showed mercy. That anger is still in most rooms, aimed at somebody.

But it displeased Jonah exceedingly, and he was angry. And he prayed to the LORD and said, "O LORD, is not this what I said when I was yet in my country? That is why I made haste to flee to Tarshish; for I knew that you are a gracious God and merciful, slow to anger and abounding in steadfast love, and relenting from disaster." And the LORD said, "You pity the plant, for which you did not labor, nor did you make it grow... And should not I pity Nineveh, that great city, in which there are more than 120,000 persons who do not know their right hand from their left, and also much cattle?"

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. Jonah can quote God's mercy perfectly. What is his actual problem with it? CORE

Leader. He wants mercy for himself and judgment for Nineveh. Right theology, wrong joy.

2. God compares Nineveh to the plant Jonah pitied. What is God saying about the value of people Jonah had written off?

Leader. Jonah grieved a plant. God grieved a city. Mercy sees persons, not categories.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. 1 Peter 1:3 ties mercy to a new birth and a living hope, not only to a canceled penalty. What did mercy do for us, beyond "not getting in trouble"? CORE

Leader. Mercy is not God looking the other way. It causes new life through the resurrection.

4. James 2:13 says mercy triumphs over judgment. How can a church show mercy without pretending sin is small? Use the drawing if it helps: stocks still standing, fruit

on the table.

Leader. Both have to stay in the picture. Mercy that denies the sentence is sentiment. Sentence without mercy is not the gospel.

5. Who is your Nineveh — a group you quietly hope will “get what’s coming”? You do not have to name them. What would good fruit, instead of rotten fruit, look like toward them this week?

Leader. Push for a practice: a conversation, a prayer, refusing a slur, a meal. Not a vague “be nicer.”

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Mercy is God not giving us the judgment we had earned, and giving us life instead.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Thank God that your group is not outside His mercy.
2. Confess Jonah’s instinct: mercy for me, payback for them.
3. Ask for one concrete act of mercy before you meet again.

Before you stumble

If someone asks the difference between mercy and grace, give it in one sentence and move on: mercy withholds the punishment we deserve; grace gives the feast we could never earn. Next week is the feast. Do not preview it for ten minutes.

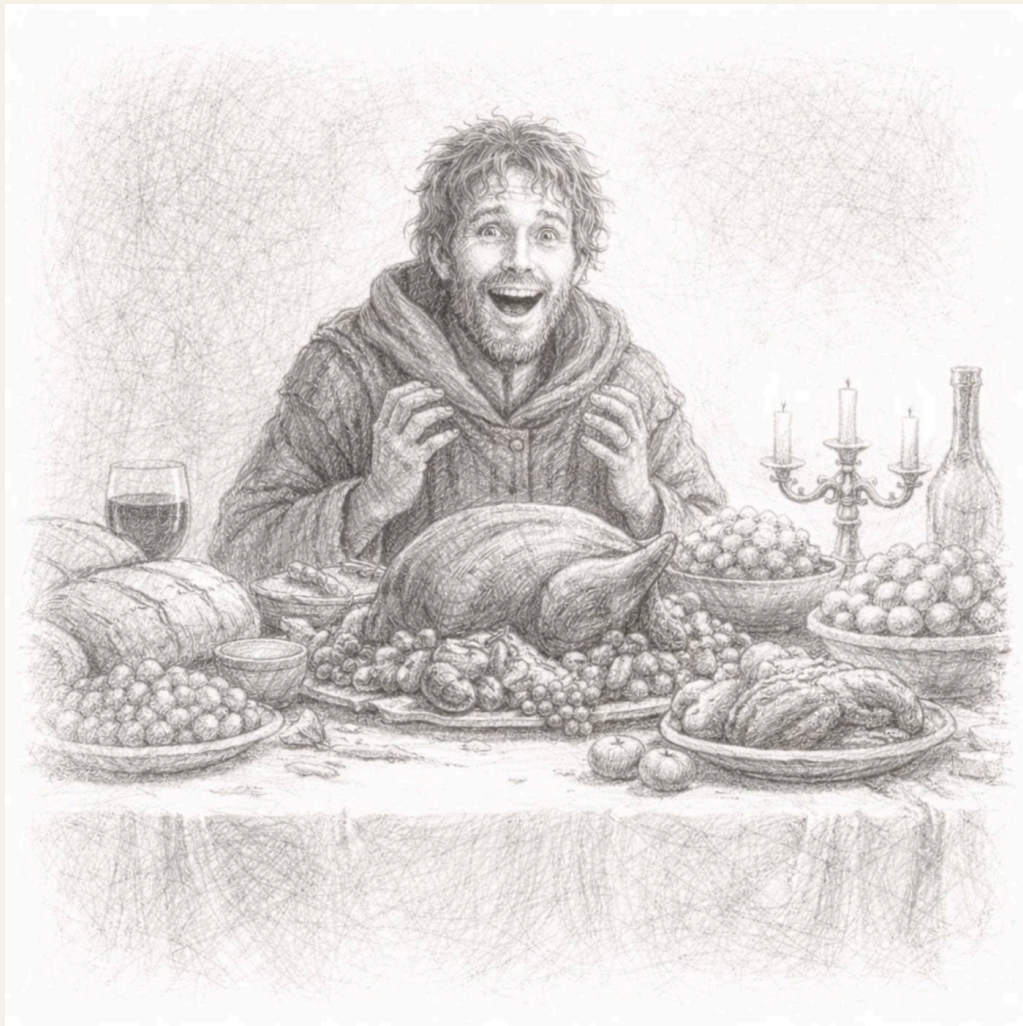
WITH STUDENTS

Ask where students see “you get what you deserve” treated as the highest justice — online, in sports, at school. Then ask whether they want God to run the world only that way, including toward them.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Luke 6:35–36. Jesus tells disciples to be merciful as the Father is merciful, including toward the ungrateful. Read it only if the Jonah conversation is still thin.

Grace



A man in a worn coat sits wide-eyed at a table he did not set: bread, meat, fruit, wine. He brought his hunger. God brought the meal.

Before you gather

- Read Day 4, Grace, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read 2 Samuel 9:6–8, 13 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

What is something good in your life you know you could not have bought for yourself?

Leader. Stay off the devotion's "best gift you ever received" question. This one is about inability, which is where grace lives. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Look at his face. He knows this table is not his. Grace is not God topping up what we already cooked. It is God feeding people who came in empty.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Grace is God's unmerited favor freely given to sinners who deserve judgment, granting them salvation, forgiveness, and every spiritual blessing through Jesus Christ. It is not earned, deserved, or repaid; it flows from God's sovereign goodness and love.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek charis — grace, favor, a gift freely given.

MEMORY VERSE • EPHESIANS 2:8–9

For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast.

Together, open the flashcard for Grace. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 • OPEN THE BIBLE • 15 MIN

2 Samuel 9:6–8, 13

Mephibosheth is not in the chapter. A lame man from a fallen house is seated at the king's table for someone else's sake. That is the drawing, in a story.

And Mephibosheth the son of Jonathan, son of Saul, came to David and fell on his face and paid homage. And David said, "Mephibosheth!" And he answered, "Behold, I am your servant." And David said to him, "Do not fear, for I will show you kindness for the sake of your father Jonathan, and I will restore to you all the land of Saul your father, and you shall eat at my table always." And he paid homage and said, "What is your servant, that you should show regard for a dead dog such as I?" ... So Mephibosheth lived in Jerusalem, for he ate always at the king's table.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. What had Mephibosheth done to earn a seat? What, exactly, did David give him?

CORE

Leader. Nothing earned. Land restored, fear lifted, a permanent place at the table, and the reason is Jonathan, not Mephibosheth's résumé.

2. He calls himself "a dead dog." Does David argue with that self-portrait, or does he simply set a place for him?

Leader. Grace does not wait for a healthier self-image. It seats the person who knows he does not belong.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Ephesians 2:8–9 says the gift includes the faith that receives it, "so that no one may boast." What do we still try to slide onto the table as our contribution? CORE

Leader. Sincerity, a decision, a sad enough repentance, church loyalty, not being as bad as someone else.

4. Romans 6:1 asks if we should sin so grace will abound. Where does “grace means my sin does not matter” misunderstand the feast?

Leader. The table is for transformation as well as welcome. Titus 2:11–12: grace trains us. It is not a permit.

5. 2 Corinthians 8:9: He became poor so we might become rich. Grace was free to us and costly to Him. How does remembering the cost keep gratitude from turning into entitlement?

Leader. Entitlement says “of course.” Worship says “it cost Him.” Ask what entitlement sounds like in prayer.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Grace is God giving sinners the opposite of what they deserve, at Jesus’ cost, as a gift.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Thank God for a seat you did not earn.
2. Name one boast you keep wanting to add.
3. Ask that grace would train the group this week, not only comfort it.

Before you stumble

Part I ends here. Do not start Part II tonight unless you have time for a clean handoff. A good last line: “Next time we tell the truth about why this table was

necessary.” Some in the room may not feel like sinners yet. Do not force a testimony. The text can indict gently.

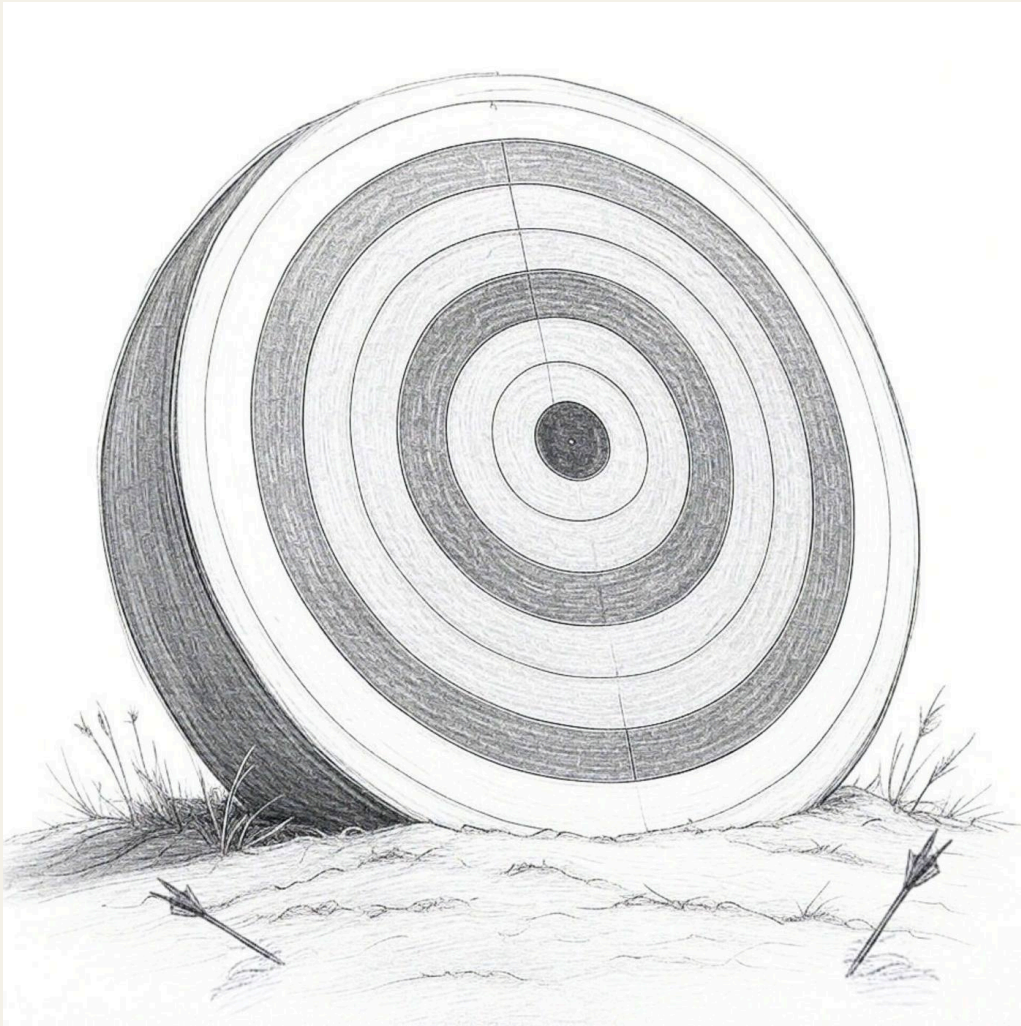
WITH STUDENTS

Ask what a team banquet feels like if you did not make the team and the coach seats you anyway. Then ask who paid for the meal. Keep Jesus as the cost, not the coach as the hero.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Titus 2:11–14. Grace appeared, and grace trains. Use it if Romans 6 needs a second witness.

Sin



A full target, and not one arrow in it. The arrows are in the grass. Missing is the point of the drawing, including the shots we never took.

OPEN PART II BY SAYING

The feast only makes sense if we were starving, and worse than starving. These five weeks tell the truth about sin, death, wrath, judgment, and a real guilty verdict. Do not soften them into low self-esteem. Do not leave the room without pointing at Christ.

Before you gather

- Read Day 5, Sin, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Matthew 5:21–22, 27–28 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

1 · ICEBREAKER · 7 MIN

Open the room

What is a rule you broke as a kid that you were sure no one would notice?

Leader. Laugh and move. Do not collect childhood shame stories. That is the devotion's question, and it is already done. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 · THE WORD · 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Nobody in this drawing gets a consolation prize for trying. The arrows are not close. Sin is falling short of God's glory — His character — not falling short of the person next to you.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Sin is any failure to conform to the moral law of God in act, attitude, or nature, whether by doing what God forbids or failing to do what He commands.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek hamartia — to miss the mark, to err, to trespass.

MEMORY VERSE · ROMANS 3:23

For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God.

Together, open the flashcard for Sin. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

Matthew 5:21–22, 27–28

Jesus moves the target from the act to the heart. The devotion already pressed guilt, Romans 2, and the Pharisee and the tax collector. Stay in the Sermon on the Mount.

You have heard that it was said to those of old, “You shall not murder; and whoever murders will be liable to judgment.” But I say to you that everyone who is angry with his brother will be liable to judgment. You have heard that it was said, “You shall not commit adultery.” But I say to you that everyone who looks at a woman with lustful intent has already committed adultery with her in his heart.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. According to Jesus, where does the arrow leave the path — only when the act happens, or earlier? **CORE**

Leader. Anger and lust are already off the mark. The heart is in bounds or out of bounds before the hands move.

2. Who is Jesus talking to — obvious criminals, or religious people who thought they were hitting the target?

Leader. Disciples and crowds who knew the commandments. Respectable missing still misses.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. James 4:17 says that knowing the right thing and failing to do it is sin. The drawing has arrows that were never shot. Why is omission harder for us to call sin than a loud failure? **CORE**

Leader. We prosecute what we did. God also names what we withheld: truth, help, worship, justice.

4. Romans 3:23 says we fall short of the glory of God, not of other people. Why do we prefer to grade ourselves on a curve?

Leader. Comparison keeps us feeling like archers. The standard is God's own glory.

5. 1 John 1:8–9 says denying sin is self-deception, and confessing it is the way into fellowship. What makes honest confession feel dangerous in a group like this?

Leader. Image, leadership, family roles. You are not asking anyone to dump a secret tonight. You are asking why the room stays polished.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Sin is missing God's mark in what we do, what we want, and what we fail to do.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Ask God to show the group the real target, not a softer one.
2. Confess, in silence, one miss you have renamed as a personality trait.
3. Thank Him that diagnosis is mercy when a Physician is in the room. Do not preach week 19. Just do not leave them in the grass.

Before you stumble

Part II begins. Read the part line at the top before the icebreaker. Watch the shame spiral: some people will over-talk their failures to prove sincerity. Thank them, and remind the room we name sin in order to bring it to Christ, not to perform it. Also watch the minimizer. Both are missing.

WITH STUDENTS

Students hear sin as “the big list.” Have them finish the sentence: “I would never ___ , so I’m fine.” Then reread Matthew 5 and ask what Jesus would say back.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Genesis 3:1–13, if you want the first miss in narrative form. Do not allegory it to death. Ask one question: where do they hide, and from whom?

Depravity



A boat, high and dry, hull tired, grass in the seams. It is not a little off course. It is not sailing.

Before you gather

- Read Day 6, Depravity, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Ezekiel 37:1–6, 9–10 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

Open the room

Have you ever tried to push a car with a dead battery? What finally had to happen?

Leader. The answer you want, eventually, is “someone else had to bring life.” Do not say it for them during the icebreaker. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: A drifting boat still has a sailor. This one does not. Depravity means every part of us is affected by the fall, and apart from grace we cannot push ourselves back into the water.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Depravity refers to the deep corruption of human nature due to sin, resulting in our inability to please God, understand spiritual truth rightly, or come to Him apart from His grace.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek nekros — dead, lifeless, without power. The day’s text calls us dead, not merely damaged.

MEMORY VERSE • EPHESIANS 2:1–2

And you were dead in the trespasses and sins in which you once walked, following the course of this world, following the prince of the power of the air, the spirit that is now at work in the sons of disobedience.

Together, open the flashcard for Depravity. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

Ezekiel 37:1–6, 9–10

The devotion asked about spiritual blindness and about Romans 6. Ezekiel's valley makes the same point with bones that cannot hear until God speaks. Read it as a story.

The hand of the LORD was upon me, and he brought me out in the Spirit of the LORD and set me down in the middle of the valley; it was full of bones... and behold, they were very dry. And he said to me, "Son of man, can these bones live?" And I answered, "O Lord GOD, you know." Then he said to me, "Prophecy over these bones... Behold, I will cause breath to enter you, and you shall live." So I prophesied as he commanded me, and the breath came into them, and they lived and stood on their feet, an exceedingly great army.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. What can the bones do for themselves in this story? Who acts? CORE

Leader. They are very dry. They do not decide, cooperate, or improve. God speaks, and breath comes.

2. God asks, "Can these bones live?" Ezekiel does not say yes. He says, "Lord, you know." Why is that a better answer than optimism?

Leader. Hope is in God's power, not in the bones' potential. Depravity kills our confidence in human potential without killing our confidence in God.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Ephesians 2 says "dead," not "sick" or "confused." What is the difference between "people need a little help believing" and "people need to be made alive"? CORE

Leader. Help still assumes a living patient. Death requires resurrection. This changes evangelism and parenting.

4. Romans 8:7–8 says the mind set on the flesh cannot submit to God’s law. Why does that offend us — and why might it be good news if it is true?

Leader. It offends pride. It is good news because the solution is no longer “try harder to be the kind of person who starts the boat.”

5. John 6:44: no one comes to Jesus unless the Father draws him. How should that change the way we pray for people who seem unable to care about God?

Leader. Prayer stops being a backup plan. If they are dead, asking God to speak is the work, alongside telling them the news.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Apart from Jesus we are not weak swimmers. We are dead, and only God can make us alive.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Thank God for any spiritual breath in the room. It did not come from the bones.
2. Pray by name, if people are willing, for someone who seems dry.
3. Ask for humility. This doctrine is about us before it is about “those people.”

Before you stumble

Total depravity is not “everyone is as bad as they could be.” People still love their children and tell some truth. It means every part is touched, and we cannot save ourselves or even want the true God on our own. Say that plainly if the phrase scares someone. Pastoral line: this is a spiritual diagnosis, not a comment on their

dignity, their depression, or their worth. The image of God from week 1 still stands. A wrecked boat is still a boat someone made.

WITH STUDENTS

Use the car with the dead battery, not abstract inability. Ask: "What is something you cannot make yourself want?" Then connect that to loving God.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

John 11:38–44, Lazarus. Same point, shorter if Ezekiel ran long: the dead man comes out because Jesus calls.

Wrath



A storm drops out of a wide sky toward one tree in an open field. Nothing stands between the weather and the tree.

Before you gather

- Read Day 7, Wrath, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Nahum 1:2–3, 7 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

When have you been glad that someone in authority got angry — a parent, a coach, a judge, a friend?

Leader. You are rehabilitating anger as moral, not cruel, before you open the text. Keep stories short. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: This is not God losing His temper. Wrath is His holiness, aimed. The tree is exposed. If we never feel that exposure, we will treat the cross as a kind gesture instead of a rescue.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

The wrath of God is His holy revulsion against sin and His just judgment against sinners who rebel against His righteous standards.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek orgē — settled anger, righteous wrath, not a tantrum.

MEMORY VERSE • ROMANS 1:18

For the wrath of God is revealed from heaven against all ungodliness and unrighteousness of men, who by their unrighteousness suppress the truth.

Together, open the flashcard for Wrath. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 • OPEN THE BIBLE • 15 MIN

Nahum 1:2–3, 7

The devotion already used Jesus cleansing the temple. Nahum holds wrath and refuge in the same chapter, which is the conversation you want.

The LORD is a jealous and avenging God; the LORD is avenging and wrathful; the LORD takes vengeance on his adversaries and keeps wrath for his enemies. The LORD is slow to anger and great in power, and the LORD will by no means clear the guilty. The LORD is good, a stronghold in the day of trouble; he knows those who take refuge in him.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. List what this passage says God is against, and what He is for. Do not skip either list. CORE

Leader. Against adversaries and guilt. For the refuge of those who come to Him. Both lines are in the same breath.

2. "Slow to anger" and "will by no means clear the guilty" sit side by side. What would be lost if we kept only one of those lines?

Leader. Only slow: evil never matters. Only wrath: nobody can come home. The gospel needs both.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. If God never grew angry at cruelty, what would that say about how He feels toward the people cruelty crushes? CORE

Leader. Wrath is love's refusal to call evil "fine." Let victims in the room hear that God is not neutral.

4. Romans 1:18 says wrath "is revealed," present tense, not only at the end. Where do you see a world already living with the consequences of pushing God out?

Leader. Romans 1 itself lists the fruit. Stay observable: lies treated as freedom, bodies used, truth suppressed. No partisan speech.

5. How do we talk about God's wrath to a friend without sounding like we enjoy it? What must the next sentence be?

Leader. The next sentence is the cross: the storm has a lightning rod. If they cannot say that second sentence, they are not ready to say the first one in public.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

God's wrath is His holy love refusing to make peace with evil.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Praise God that He is not indifferent to evil.
2. Confess any place you have enjoyed the idea of someone else under the storm.
3. Ask for courage and tenderness the next time you have to tell the truth about judgment.

Before you stumble

Two failures: mocking people who struggle with wrath, and gloating as if we were the lightning. Tone is everything this week. Wrath is settled opposition to sin, not God being moody. If the room is young or new, do not camp in descriptions of hell. Camp in Nahum: He will not clear the guilty, and He is a stronghold. Week 14 will show where the bolt lands. You may say that in one sentence.

WITH STUDENTS

Ask what kind of god they would actually want in charge if someone hurt their sibling. Most will want a god who gets angry. Then ask whether they want that same God reading their group chat.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Psalm 7:11–12. God is righteous and indignant every day, and He offers repentance before the bow is drawn. Use it if someone thinks wrath means no warnings.

Judgment



A judge's bench, formal and empty. The chair is still vacant. The courtroom is not a metaphor we control. The session has not started. It is on the calendar.

Before you gather

- Read Day 8, Judgment, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Acts 17:30–31 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

Open the room

If your whole week were played on a screen for this group, what ten-second clip would you want to skip? You can pass, and you do not have to be heroic.

Leader. Light embarrassment is enough. Shut down oversharing. You are introducing exposure, not collecting sins. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: The chair is empty, not retired. Judgment is appointed. The delay is not God forgetting, and it is not permission to live as if the bench will stay empty.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Judgment is God fairly judging every person's life and giving what is due according to His holy and righteous standard. For those apart from Jesus the verdict is always guilty, resulting in eternal punishment.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek krisis — a separating, a trial, a decision, a judgment.

MEMORY VERSE • HEBREWS 9:27

And just as it is appointed for man to die once, and after that comes judgment.

Together, open the flashcard for Judgment. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

Acts 17:30–31

Hebrews 4 was the devotion's second question. Acts 17 puts the day of judgment in a sermon to people who were not Bible insiders, and it ties the date to a resurrection.

The times of ignorance God overlooked, but now he commands all people everywhere to repent, because he has fixed a day on which he will judge the world in righteousness by a man whom he has appointed; and of this he has given assurance to all by raising him from the dead.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. What has God fixed, whom has He appointed to do it, and what is the proof Paul offers? **CORE**

Leader. A day. A man, Jesus. The resurrection. Judgment is not a vibe. It is scheduled, personal, and public.

2. Paul is speaking to philosophers, not to church people. What does “all people everywhere” do to the idea that judgment is only a religious topic?

Leader. The bench has jurisdiction over the whole city, including people who find the idea embarrassing.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Hebrews 9:27 puts death and judgment in one sentence, the way we put birthdays on a calendar. Why do we organize ordinary life as if the second half of that sentence were optional?

Leader. Busyness, medicine, entertainment, even ministry can function as a way not to look at the chair.

4. Read Hebrews 9:28 right after 9:27. Judgment is appointed — and so is a second appearing of Christ, “not to deal with sin but to save those who are eagerly waiting for him.” What is the difference between those two futures? **CORE**

Leader. This is the gospel turn the devotion did not take. For the person in Christ, the Judge is also the Savior who already dealt with sin. Do not skip John 5:24 if fear fills the room: the believer does not come into condemnation.

5. Romans 2:11: God shows no partiality. Whose sin do we grade on a curve, and whose do we not — in our church, our family, our news feed?

Leader. The curve usually favors people like us. Let that land without turning the night into politics.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

A real Judge is coming. His standard is His own righteousness, not our excuses.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Thank God that the empty chair means there is still time.
2. Pray for someone who is living as if the bench were a myth.
3. Thank Him that the appointed Judge is the same Jesus who bore sin. Ask for eagerness, not only relief.

Before you stumble

Do not flatten this into “Christians never face any evaluation.” Second Corinthians 5:10 says we appear before Christ’s seat. For believers that is not a condemnation hearing; the verdict of justification stands. It is still a real appearing. If that distinction is too much for the room, stick to John 5:24 and Hebrews 9:27–28 and leave the finer point in your pocket.

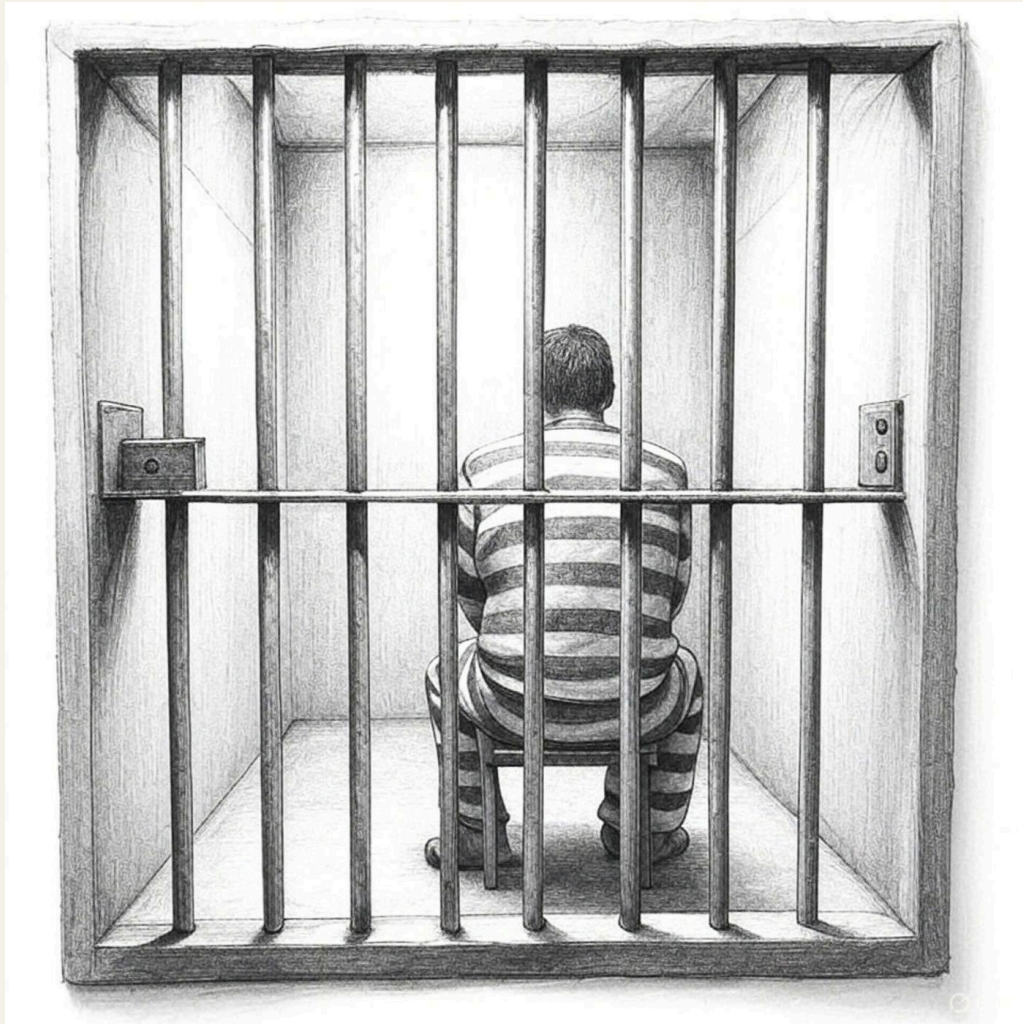
WITH STUDENTS

Ask what would change this month if they actually believed a day was fixed. Push past “I’d be nicer” to something dated: a conversation, a habit, an apology.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Ecclesiastes 12:13–14. God will bring every deed into judgment, including hidden things. Read it if the group thinks only public scandal counts.

Condemnation



A man in prison stripes sits with his back to us. A bar locks the door. We are not watching a bad day. We are looking at a sentence.

Before you gather

- Read Day 9, Condemnation, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Galatians 3:10, 13–14 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

What is a courtroom moment from a movie or a show you still remember? Did you agree with the verdict?

Leader. Fiction keeps this from becoming “tell us about your guilt,” which they already did in the book. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Condemnation is not God being disappointed. It is a verdict. John says the person who does not believe is condemned already. The cell is not a future possibility for those outside Christ. The door is already shut — and there is a pardon that opens it.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Condemnation is God’s judicial verdict of guilt for sinners, resulting in the sentence of judgment and eternal separation from God. It is the opposite of justification.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek katakrima — a sentence of guilt, an adverse verdict.

MEMORY VERSE • JOHN 3:18

Whoever believes in him is not condemned, but whoever does not believe is condemned already, because he has not believed in the name of the only Son of God.

Together, open the flashcard for Condemnation. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 • OPEN THE BIBLE • 15 MIN

Galatians 3:10, 13–14

Romans 8:1 was their reflection question. Galatians 3 shows the curse and the exchange: someone else became what we were.

For all who rely on works of the law are under a curse; for it is written, “Cursed be everyone who does not abide by all things written in the Book of the Law, and do them.” Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us — for it is written, “Cursed is everyone who is hanged on a tree” — so that in Christ Jesus the blessing of Abraham might come to the Gentiles, so that we might receive the promised Spirit through faith.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. Who is under the curse in verse 10, and what did Christ become in verse 13? **CORE**

Leader. Everyone who tries to stand on law-keeping is under the curse, because the law requires all of it. Christ became the curse. The sentence moved.

2. What arrives on the other side of that exchange, according to verse 14? It is more than a cleared record.

Leader. The blessing of Abraham, and the Spirit, through faith. The cell door opens onto an inheritance, not onto a parole office.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. John 3:18 says the unbeliever is “condemned already,” not waiting to become guilty. How does that change the way we talk to a friend who thinks they are a decent person on a spiritual journey? **CORE**

Leader. Evangelism is not “try to become acceptable.” It is “the verdict is in; there is a pardon with a name on it.”

4. Romans 8:33–34 asks who will bring a charge and who will condemn, and answers with the risen Christ. Why is a living Jesus, and not only a forgiving feeling, the end of the prosecution?

Leader. The defense attorney is the one who died and now lives at God's right hand. The case cannot be reopened by the accuser.

5. Where do Christians still live as if the bar on that door were locked — replaying a sin, a parent's voice, a failure — even though the sentence has been served by someone else?

Leader. Distinguish condemnation from conviction. The Spirit exposes sin to lead us to Christ (John 16:8). The accuser exposes sin to send us back to the cell. Help the room hear the difference.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Condemnation is the guilty verdict. In Christ, that verdict is not ours to carry.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Thank Christ for becoming the curse.
2. Pray for someone still inside John 3:18's second half.
3. Ask God to silence accusation that pretends to be holiness.

Before you stumble

Part II ends here. The next gathering is the manger. Do not relieve the tension by skipping ahead for fifteen minutes, but do not dismiss the room under the curse either. The last word tonight, if you are short, is Galatians 3:13, not a list of failures. Never ask who has been incarcerated. The drawing is about a verdict before God.

WITH STUDENTS

"Condemned already" sounds harsh. Ask: if a doctor says the disease is already present, is that cruelty or clarity? Then ask what the treatment is, and refuse any answer except Christ.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

John 5:24. Whoever hears and believes has passed from death to life and does not come into judgment. A good verse to leave in their hands.

Incarnation



A baby asleep in a feeding trough, straw on the ground, ordinary wood. Glory, taking a nap.

OPEN PART III BY SAYING

Everything before this asked why we need a Savior. These weeks answer with a Person. Incarnation through covenant: He came, He announced, He saved, He died, He stands between, He bought, He made peace, He canceled the debt, and He bound Himself by blood.

OPTIONAL, THREE MINUTES

Optional three minutes before you start, only if the group has actually been here for Part I and Part II: In one sentence, why could we not fix what weeks 5 through 9 described? Then open the manger. The answer you are listening for is not “we needed to try harder.”

Before you gather

- Read Day 10, Incarnation, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Hebrews 2:14–18 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day’s reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

1 · ICEBREAKER · 7 MIN

Open the room

What is the most ordinary place you have ever met someone who turned out to matter a great deal?

Leader. Ordinary places. The manger is an ordinary place. Do not ask their favorite thing about Christmas. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 · THE WORD · 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: God did not shout the gospel from a safe distance. The eternal Son took a real body, in a real feeding box. Fully God, fully man, one person. Not half and half. Not God in a costume.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

The incarnation is the act of the second person of the Trinity, the eternal Son of God, assuming a full and true human nature, becoming fully God and fully man in one person, Jesus Christ, to accomplish the work of redemption.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek sarx — flesh. The Word became flesh, a real human life.

MEMORY VERSE · JOHN 1:14

And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory, glory as of the only Son from the Father, full of grace and truth.

Together, open the flashcard for Incarnation. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 · OPEN THE BIBLE · 15 MIN

Hebrews 2:14–18

Matthew 1:21 was the devotion's question. Hebrews 2 tells you why flesh was required: to die, to disarm the devil, and to become a priest who has actually suffered.

Since therefore the children share in flesh and blood, he himself likewise partook of the same things, that through death he might destroy the one who has the power of death, that is, the devil, and deliver all those who through fear of death were subject to lifelong slavery. Therefore he had to be made like his brothers in every respect, so that he might become a merciful and faithful high priest in the service of God, to make propitiation for the sins of the people. For because he himself has suffered when tempted, he is able to help those who are being tempted.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. Why, according to these verses, did the Son have to share our flesh and blood?

Name more than one reason if the text gives it. **CORE**

Leader. To die, to break the devil's grip, to free people afraid of death, and to be a priest who can really help. Incarnation is for salvation, not for a seasonal feeling.

2. Verse 17 says He had to be made like us "in every respect." What would be missing if Jesus only appeared human?

Leader. No real death, no real temptation faced, no real priesthood. A costume cannot make propitiation.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. John 1:14 says He “dwelt” among us — He pitched His tent. What does a manger say that a throne, by itself, could not say?

Leader. Nearness. God comes into hunger, night, and poverty. Glory you can see, full of grace and truth.

4. Hebrews 4:15: tempted in every way as we are, yet without sin. Why does it matter, on a hard week, that Jesus is not pretending to understand? **CORE**

Leader. Help is from someone who has been in a body. Do not imply He sinned. The text says the opposite, and that is why His help is clean.

5. Where do we treat Jesus as an idea, a mood, or a distant coach instead of a person who took a real life and still has one?

Leader. Prayer that never addresses Him, a gospel with no resurrection body, worship that wants a feeling more than a Lord.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

God the Son took on a real human life so He could live, die, and rise for us.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · PRAY · 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Worship Jesus as God and as brother.
2. Bring Him a temptation someone in the room is actually facing. Ask for the help Hebrews 2:18 promises.
3. Thank Him for coming near instead of sending instructions.

Before you stumble

This is the first week of Part III. Read the part opener. Correct gently, if needed: He did not become God at Bethlehem or at His baptism. He is the eternal Son who assumed a human nature. He did not stop being God in the manger. If someone is grieving, the priest who suffered is the pastoral gold in this passage. Do not rush past verse 18 to keep the outline.

WITH STUDENTS

Ask: "Could Jesus have saved us by staying in heaven and sending a message?" Make them answer from Hebrews 2, not from a slogan. The death requires the flesh.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Philippians 2:5–11, if you want the descent and the exaltation in one sweep. It also gives the group a mind to imitate, not only a doctrine to admire.

Gospel



A crier lifts a horn in a crowded street. People lean in, faces open. He is not leading a seminar. He is announcing something that has happened.

Before you gather

- Read Day 11, Gospel, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read 1 Corinthians 15:1–5 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

What is news you could not keep to yourself — a birth, a score, a job, a recovery? How fast did you tell somebody?

Leader. Speed and joy. You are training the instinct to announce. Do not ask “the best news you have ever received.” They answered that in the book. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: The drawing is a town hearing news. The gospel is not first “here is how to live.” It is “here is what God has done in Jesus.” If we turn it into tips, we have put the horn down.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

The gospel is the good news of what God has done in Jesus Christ to save sinners through His life, death, resurrection, and exaltation, calling all people to repent and believe for forgiveness of sins and eternal life.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek euangelion — good news, a message announced, not advice offered.

MEMORY VERSE • LUKE 2:10–11

And the angel said to them, “Fear not, for behold, I bring you good news of great joy that will be for all the people. For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Savior, who is Christ the Lord.”

Together, open the flashcard for Gospel. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 • OPEN THE BIBLE • 15 MIN

1 Corinthians 15:1–5

Paul tells a church what the gospel is, of first importance: events, in history, according to the Scriptures. This is the definition text, and it was not their reflection assignment.

Now I would remind you, brothers, of the gospel I preached to you, which you received, in which you stand, and by which you are being saved, if you hold fast to the word I preached to you — unless you believed in vain. For I delivered to you as of first importance what I also received: that Christ died for our sins in accordance with the Scriptures, that he was buried, that he was raised on the third day in accordance with the Scriptures, and that he appeared to Cephas, then to the twelve.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. Paul lists events. What are they? What kinds of things are missing from his list?

CORE

Leader. Died for sins, buried, raised, seen. Missing: advice, politics, self-help, even many true doctrines. The center is Christ's saving work in history.

2. He says "of first importance," and that they are being saved by it if they hold fast. What would it mean for a church to keep this news first instead of merely agreeing it is true?

Leader. First means other good things — community, mercy ministries, moral reform — stay servants of the announcement, not replacements for it.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Where have we turned the gospel into tips for a better life? Name a phrase we use that could be said by someone who does not believe Jesus rose. CORE

Leader. "Follow your heart," "be a good person," "live generously," even "God has a plan" with no cross. The horn has to say Christ.

4. Romans 1:16 calls the gospel the power of God, not only information. Have you seen this news do something an argument could not do?

Leader. Stories of a changed will, a repaired conscience, courage. If the room is quiet, tell one of your own in four sentences and ask again.

5. Isaiah 52:7 says the feet of the messenger are beautiful because the news is. If this is public news and not a private hobby, what would a simple announcement sound like in ordinary words to a neighbor?

Leader. Have two people try it out loud, badly. Clumsy and true beats polished and vague. Do not make this the devotion's "who will you tell today" guilt trip. Practice the sentence.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

The gospel is the announcement that Jesus died for sins, was buried, and rose again, and that we must turn and trust Him.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Thank God for news this good.
2. Ask forgiveness for the times we have made it smaller than Christ.
3. Ask for one open door this week to say the sentence out loud.

Before you stumble

Guard the word "gospel." People will use it for everything they like about church. Bring them back to 1 Corinthians 15. The other weeks are facets of this news, not

replacements. If a guest is here, this is the week they can actually hear the announcement. Do not assume the room.

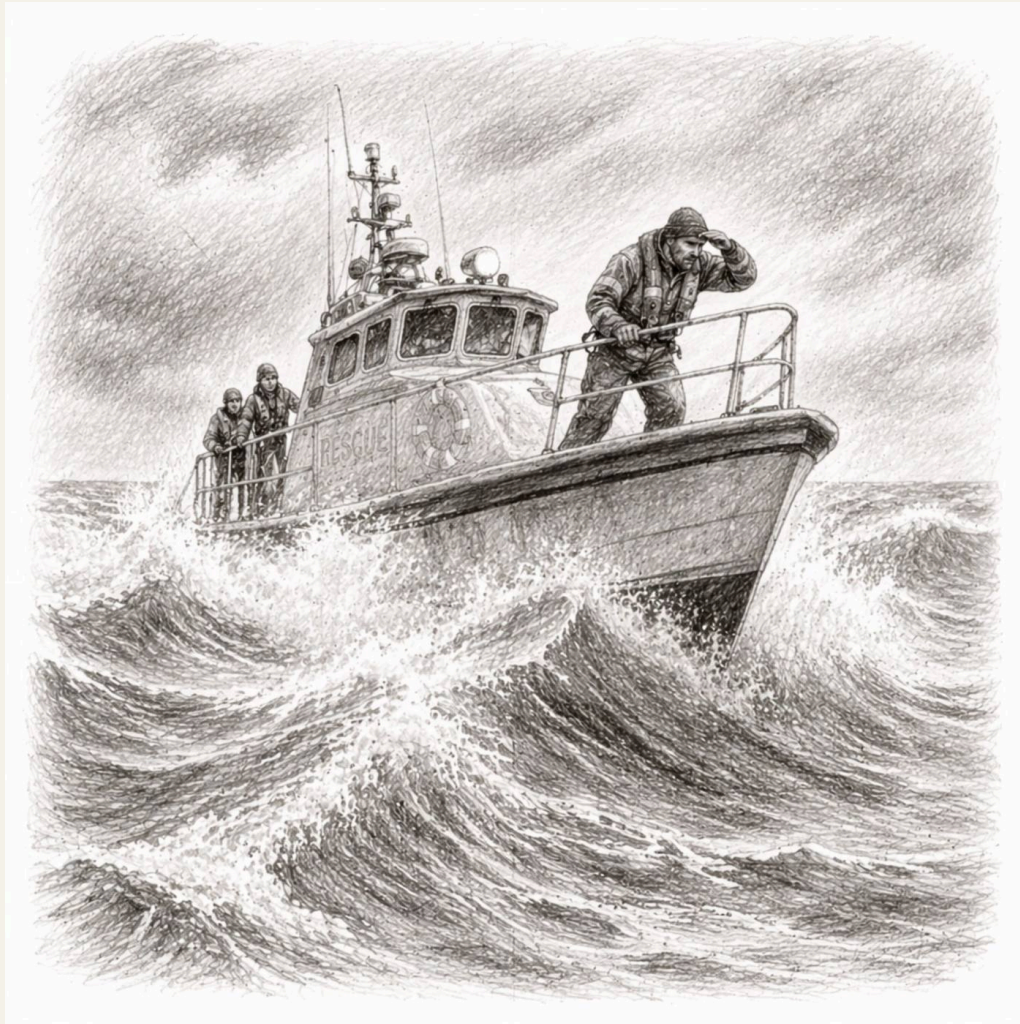
WITH STUDENTS

Have a student explain the gospel in thirty seconds without the words “just” or “relationship,” then let the group add only what 1 Corinthians 15 requires. It will be humbling and useful.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Acts 2:22–24, 36–38. Peter’s announcement ends in “repent and be baptized.” Use it if the group separates the news from the response.

Salvation



A rescue boat climbs a wave that could bury it. The hull says RESCUE. The crew is already in the weather. Nobody on deck is lecturing the drowning about their stroke.

Before you gather

- Read Day 12, Salvation, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Exodus 14:13–14, 30–31 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

Open the room

When have you been lost — a store as a child, a trail, a parking garage, a city — and had to be found? What did your body do when you realized someone was coming?

Leader. Relief is physical. You are after that feeling, not a spiritual autobiography. The book already asked what they were drowning in. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Salvation is not coaching. The boat comes into the sea you cannot survive. God rescues. We are not the crew that saved ourselves and then offered God a ride.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Salvation is the gracious and sovereign act of God in which He rescues sinners from sin and judgment through faith in Jesus Christ, restores them to fellowship with Himself, and grants them eternal life by the power of His Spirit.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek *sōtēria* — salvation, deliverance, safety, being brought out.

MEMORY VERSE · ROMANS 1:16

For I am not ashamed of the gospel, for it is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes, to the Jew first and also to the Greek.

Together, open the flashcard for Salvation. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

Exodus 14:13–14, 30–31

Psalms 18 was the devotion's mirror passage. Exodus 14 is the church's basic picture of salvation: an enemy, a sea, a God who fights, a people who did not part the water.

And Moses said to the people, "Fear not, stand firm, and see the salvation of the LORD, which he will work for you today. For the Egyptians whom you see today, you shall never see again. The LORD will fight for you, and you have only to be silent." Thus the LORD saved Israel that day from the hand of the Egyptians... and Israel saw the great power that the LORD used against the Egyptians, so the people feared the LORD, and they believed in the LORD and in his servant Moses.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. What are the people told to do? Who does the saving? CORE

Leader. Fear not, stand firm, see, be silent. The Lord saves. Their assignment is trust, not technique.

2. Verse 31 says that after they saw, they feared and believed. What came first in the story — their faith, or God's act?

Leader. God acted, they saw, then they believed. Faith receives a salvation already worked. Do not turn this into a full ordo debate.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. What are the "swim harder" versions of Christianity we still preach to ourselves and to our kids? CORE

Leader. Try harder, feel more, serve more, as if those were the motor. They are fruit. The sea was opened by God.

4. Scripture speaks of salvation as past (Ephesians 2:8), present (1 Corinthians 1:18, “being saved”), and future (Romans 13:11). Which tense do you forget, and what does that forgetfulness do to you?

Leader. Only past: no growth. Only present: no assurance. Only future: no joy now. Most of us drop one.

5. The crew went into the storm for people who could not save themselves. Who around you is still in the water, and what would it mean to point them to Christ instead of coaching their swimming?

Leader. A name, a next step: a meal, an invitation, a clear sentence. Not a project to fix them.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Salvation is God rescuing us from sin and judgment through Jesus, not us escaping on our own.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Thank God for a rescue you did not engineer.
2. Be silent for a few seconds, on purpose, as Exodus 14:14 says.
3. Pray for someone still in the water.

Before you stumble

Some believers have no cinematic testimony. The Exodus generation included complainers who were still brought through. Do not rank stories. Faith rests on

Christ's work. Also: "you have only to be silent" is not an excuse to ignore God's commands. It is the opposite of self-rescue in the moment of salvation.

WITH STUDENTS

Ask what advice adults give that sounds like swimming lessons for a drowning person. Let them be honest. Then ask what the boat actually is.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Jonah 2:9, "Salvation belongs to the LORD." One line, worth memorizing beside Romans 1:16.

Atonement



A lamb stands in the open and looks at you. Unblemished, alive, and — if you know the story — appointed to die. The softness is not the message. The innocence is.

Before you gather

- Read Day 13, Atonement, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Exodus 12:5–7, 12–13 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

Have you ever paid for something someone else broke, or taken a consequence that belonged to somebody else? Did you tell them?

Leader. Substitution, briefly. Not the book's question about covering up your own mistake. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Do not let the lamb stay cute. In Israel, a lamb died so a household could live. Atonement is a covering and a cleansing that costs a life. Jesus is that lamb, once, for those who trust Him.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Atonement is the once-for-all work of Christ in His life and sacrificial death in which He, as our substitute, bore the penalty of sin, satisfied God's wrath, fulfilled the demands of divine justice, and reconciled sinners to God, securing redemption for all who believe.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Hebrew *kapar* — to cover, to purge, to make atonement.

MEMORY VERSE • 1 PETER 2:24

He himself bore our sins in his body on the tree, that we might die to sin and live to righteousness. By his wounds you have been healed.

Together, open the flashcard for Atonement. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 • OPEN THE BIBLE • 15 MIN

Exodus 12:5–7, 12–13

Isaiah 1:18 was their reflection text. The Passover is the lamb in story form, and it matches the drawing without repeating the devotion.

Your lamb shall be without blemish, a male a year old. You may take it from the sheep or from the goats, and you shall keep it until the fourteenth day of this month, when the whole assembly of the congregation of Israel shall kill their lambs at twilight. Then they shall take some of the blood and put it on the two doorposts and the lintel of the houses in which they eat it. The blood shall be a sign for you, on the houses where you are. And when I see the blood, I will pass over you, and no plague will befall you to destroy you, when I strike the land of Egypt.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. What kind of lamb does God require, and what does the blood actually do on that night? CORE

Leader. Without blemish. The blood is a sign God sees, and He passes over. The lamb dies. The household lives. A symbol without a death would not have done this.

2. God says, “When I see the blood.” Whose obedience is the shelter — the family’s feelings, or the lamb’s blood applied?

Leader. They had to put it on the door. The saving thing God sees is the blood, not the impressiveness of the people indoors.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Hebrews 10:4 and 14: animal blood cannot take away sins, and Jesus’ one offering perfected for all time those who are being sanctified. What could the old lambs do, and what could they never do? CORE

Leader. They taught, covered for a time, and pointed. They could not finish. Christ does not repeat Passover. He fulfills it.

4. 1 Peter 2:24 holds two purposes together: He bore our sins, so that we might die to sin and live to righteousness. Which half do we quote more often, and what happens when we drop the other?

Leader. Only the bearing: no new life. Only the living: no forgiveness. Atonement is both pardon and a new direction.

5. Where do we still try to “cover” our own sin — image, excuses, religious busyness — instead of standing under the blood God sees?

Leader. Covering yourself is the opposite of atonement. You hide the door. He covers the people.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Atonement is Jesus, our substitute, covering sin by His sacrifice so we can be brought back to God.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Thank the Lamb who was slain.
2. Confess one way you try to cover yourself.
3. Ask to live to righteousness this week for a reason: His wounds, not your reputation.

Before you stumble

The book’s definition secures redemption for all who believe. If someone asks “for whom?”, use the door: the blood sheltered those under it. Do not open a debate club. Week 14 will handle wrath satisfied. A brief line is enough: the lamb had to be perfect because God is not covered by a stained sacrifice.

WITH STUDENTS

Ask why a stuffed animal on the doorpost would have been an insult. They will get “because something had to die” faster than adults will.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Isaiah 53:6–7. All we like sheep; the Lord laid iniquity on Him; He is led like a lamb. Read it as the caption under the drawing.

Propitiation



Lightning strikes the church steeple, the cross taking the bolt. The building is not the hero. The cross is where the storm lands.

Before you gather

- Read Day 14, Propitiation, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Romans 3:24–26 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

When a real storm hits your town, where do you feel safest, and why?

Leader. Shelter. You will contrast a feeling of safety with an actual lightning rod. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Week 7 showed the storm. This week shows the strike. Propitiation means wrath was not ignored and not poured on you. It was spent on Jesus. God is not a Father we calm down by being sorry enough. He provided the sacrifice.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Propitiation is the act by which God's just wrath against sin is fully satisfied through a sacrificial substitute, Jesus Christ, so that God's favor and forgiveness can be extended to sinners.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek hilasmos — a sacrifice that turns away wrath, an appeasing.

MEMORY VERSE • 1 JOHN 2:2

He is the propitiation for our sins, and not for ours only but also for the sins of the whole world.

Together, open the flashcard for Propitiation. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 • OPEN THE BIBLE • 15 MIN

Romans 3:24–26

Exodus 34 was the devotion's text. Romans 3 is the paragraph where Paul uses this word to solve a problem inside God: how He can be righteous and still justify sinners.

And are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus, whom God put forward as a propitiation by his blood, to be received by faith. This was to show God's righteousness, because in his divine forbearance he had passed over former sins. It was to show his righteousness at the present time, so that he might be just and the justifier of the one who has faith in Jesus.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. What problem of God's, not only ours, does the propitiation solve in verses 25 and 26? CORE

Leader. How a righteous God can pass over sin and still be righteous. The cross displays justice and justification together.

2. How does a person receive what God put forward? Find the phrase.

Leader. "By faith" / "received by faith." Not by intensity, pedigree, or sorrow measured in tears.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. If God "just forgave" with no cross, what would Romans 3 say had happened to His justice? CORE

Leader. He would not be just. Forgiveness without propitiation would be God pretending. The bolt has to strike somewhere.

4. Mark 15:34: "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" Who is standing in the open field from week 7's drawing?

Leader. Jesus, the Son, under wrath that was ours. Say it with weight and without theater. Then be quiet.

5. 1 John 2:2 says "the whole world," and Romans 3:25 says "received by faith." How do we honor both without telling people they are safe while they refuse Christ, or

shrinking the cross to our little circle?

Leader. See the leader note. For a young room, skip the debate and say the pastoral sentence in the note instead of hosting an argument.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

Propitiation means Jesus took the wrath we deserved, so God can be both just and the One who justifies.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · PRAY · 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Thank the Father for putting His Son forward.
2. Thank the Son for standing in the storm.
3. Pray for someone who thinks God is either too soft to judge or too hard to approach.

Before you stumble

On 1 John 2:2: John is not saying every person is automatically reconciled, and he is not saying Jesus died only for one ethnic or social circle. The cross is the only sacrifice that can turn wrath aside, and it is received by faith (Romans 3:25). A clean sentence for the room: "There is no other lightning rod. Anyone who comes to Christ will find the storm already spent on Him." If you use "sufficient for the world, effective for believers," say it as a clarification, not as a slogan to win a fight. Do not mock the question.

WITH STUDENTS

Ask: "If a substitute takes the penalty, is the judge being kind, or being unjust?"
The answer is both kind and just, which is the whole point of the word.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

1 John 4:10. Not that we loved God, but that He loved us and sent His Son to be the propitiation. Love provides the sacrifice. We do not.

Justification



A gavel has come down on the block. The sound is the point. A court has spoken. The defendant does not leave “mostly improved.” The defendant leaves with a verdict.

Before you gather

- Read Day 15, Justification, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Romans 4:4–8 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day’s reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

Have you ever been cleared of something people assumed you had done — or watched someone else be cleared? What changed the moment the decision was announced?

Leader. The moment of declaration. Not the book's question about how we justify ourselves. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Justification is God declaring the ungodly righteous because of Jesus. The gavel is grace. Say Romans 3:23 and 3:24 as one sentence tonight — week 5 learned the first half. This week is the verdict on the other side of the comma.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Justification is the judicial act of God in which He declares sinners righteous in His sight, not on the basis of their works, but solely on the basis of Christ's righteousness imputed to them and received by faith alone.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek *dikaioō* — to declare righteous. A verdict, not a process of self-improvement.

MEMORY VERSE • ROMANS 3:24

And are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus.

Together, open the flashcard for Justification. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 • OPEN THE BIBLE • 15 MIN

Romans 4:4–8

Romans 8:31–38 was the reflection reading. Romans 4 shows the mechanism: wages versus gift, and righteousness counted to someone who is ungodly.

Now to the one who works, his wages are not counted as a gift but as his due. And to the one who does not work but believes in him who justifies the ungodly, his faith is counted as righteousness, just as David also speaks of the blessing of the one to whom God counts righteousness apart from works: “Blessed are those whose lawless deeds are forgiven, and whose sins are covered; blessed is the man against whom the Lord will not count his sin.”

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. Paul contrasts wages and gift. Who gets justified in verse 5 — the impressive, or the ungodly? What is “counted” to them? **CORE**

Leader. The ungodly. Faith is counted as righteousness. This is credit, not a paycheck. God justifies the kind of person we actually are.

2. David’s blessing is about what the Lord will not count. How is “not counting sin” different from “you have caught up on your payments”?

Leader. The record is not balanced by later goodness. It is not counted. Forgiveness and credited righteousness belong together.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Philippians 3:8–9: Paul wants a righteousness that is not his own, but one that comes through faith. What righteousness are you still tempted to hand the Judge as if it were currency? **CORE**

Leader. Ministry fruit, moral improvement since conversion, a doctrinal résumé. Even real fruit is not the ground of the verdict.

4. Romans 5:1 says the justified have peace with God. That is peace of relationship, not a calm personality. What accusation still talks to you as if the gavel had not fallen?

Leader. Let people answer without fixing them in the moment. Then read verse 1 again over the answer.

5. If justification is a declaration, how is it different from sanctification — God making you actually holy over time? Why do we collapse them?

Leader. Collapsed, you think the verdict depends on this week's progress, or you think the verdict means progress does not matter. Week 27 needs this distinction already planted. One minute is enough.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

Justification means God declares sinners righteous as a gift, because of Jesus, received by faith.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · PRAY · 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Thank God for a verdict you did not earn.
2. Hand Him one false righteousness you keep carrying into court.
3. Ask for peace with God to become louder than the accusation.

Before you stumble

"Justified" does not mean "made righteous" in this passage. It means "declared righteous." Say the word declared more than once. Imputation: our sin counted to Christ, His righteousness counted to us (2 Corinthians 5:21, if you need the

second half). Do not sneer at Catholics or at anyone who says “faith and works.” Explain the text in front of you. If someone is crushed, Romans 4:5 is the verse to leave in their hand: He justifies the ungodly.

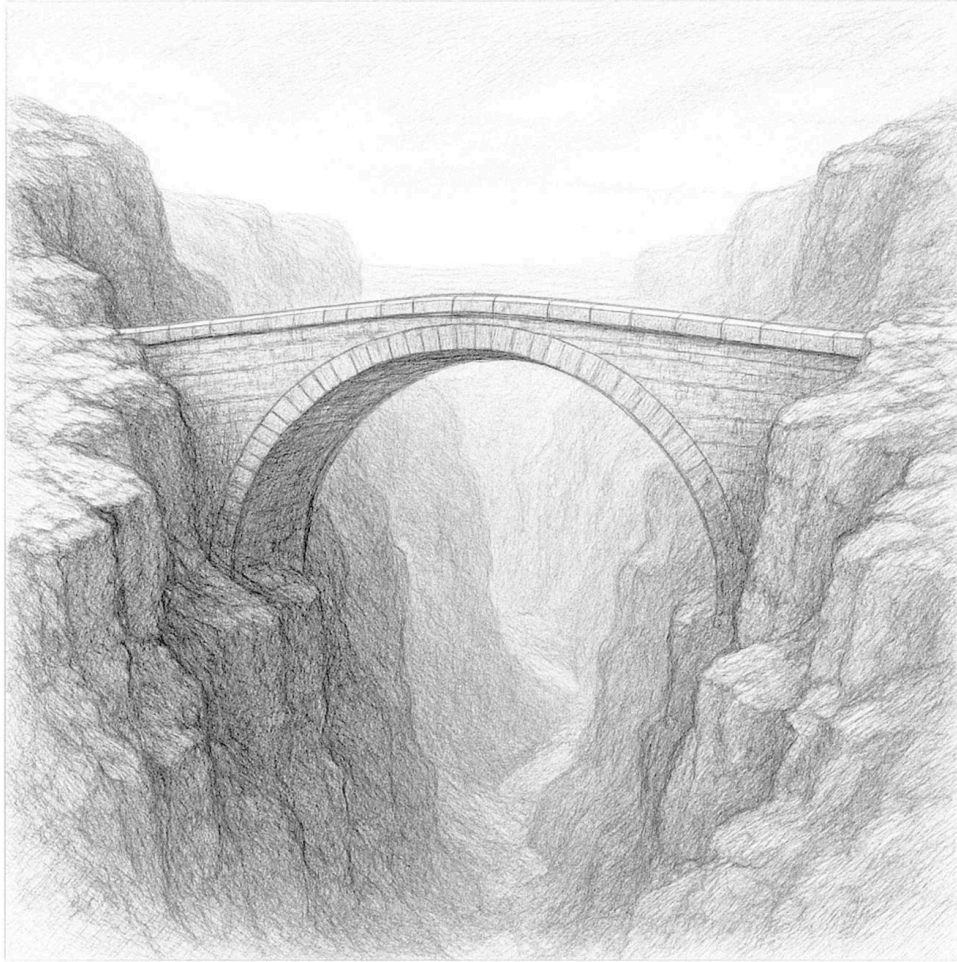
WITH STUDENTS

Use a gradebook. Justification is not extra credit that lifts a 62 to a 70. It is the teacher recording a perfect score that belongs to someone else, with your name on the line, and tearing up the old page. Ask whether that feels unfair. Then say: the Someone else asked for it.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

2 Corinthians 5:21. One verse. He was made sin; we become the righteousness of God in Him. Do not over-explain the mystery. Read it twice.

Mediation



A stone arch crosses a gorge no one is going to jump. The cliffs do not move closer. The bridge is the only way, and it had to be built from both sides.

Before you gather

- Read Day 16, Mediation, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Hebrews 7:23–25 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

What is a gap you would not try to cross without help — a road, a conversation, a bill, a language?

Leader. Gaps, not their personal story of mediating a fight. That was the book's question. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: A mediator is not a tip for a better relationship with God. A mediator is a person who belongs to both sides and brings them together. There is one. He is the man Christ Jesus, and He gave Himself.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Mediation is the work of Jesus Christ, the God-man, by which He stands between God and sinful humanity as the only representative who reconciles the two by His atoning death and ongoing intercession as our Great High Priest.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek mesitēs — one who stands in the middle, a go-between.

MEMORY VERSE • 1 TIMOTHY 2:5–6

For there is one God, and there is one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus, who gave himself as a ransom for all.

Together, open the flashcard for Mediation. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 • OPEN THE BIBLE • 15 MIN

Hebrews 7:23–25

The devotion asked why the incarnation matters for mediation. You are not repeating that. Hebrews 7 shows what the Mediator is doing now: He always lives to intercede.

The former priests were many in number, because they were prevented by death from continuing in office, but he holds his priesthood permanently, because he continues forever. Consequently, he is able to save to the uttermost those who draw near to God through him, since he always lives to make intercession for them.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. Why did the old priests have to be replaced, and why will this Priest not be? CORE

Leader. They died. He continues forever. The bridge does not collapse when a generation changes.

2. “Save to the uttermost” is tied to “always lives to make intercession.” What is Jesus doing, right now, for people who draw near?

Leader. He is praying, representing, holding. Mediation did not end at 3 p.m. on Friday.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. 1 Timothy 2:5 says there is one mediator. What other bridges do people try to lay across this gorge — good people, saints, their own sincerity, a spiritual experience?

CORE

Leader. Honor real helpers. Refuse substitutes. Drawing near is “through him,” not through a system that replaces Him.

4. Hebrews 4:16 invites us to the throne of grace for timely help. If Jesus is the bridge, why do we still pray as if we were shouting across the canyon?

Leader. We pray like outsiders. Intercession means we come with Him, not instead of Him and not without Him.

5. Who in your life is standing on the other cliff, and what would it mean to introduce them to the Mediator instead of trying to be one yourself?

Leader. We can witness. We cannot be the bridge. That relieves pressure and raises urgency.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

Jesus is the one Mediator. He brings us to God by His death, and He still prays for us.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · PRAY · 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Thank Jesus for a bridge that is a Person.
2. Draw near out loud for one specific need. Do it through Him, not around Him.
3. Pray for someone on the far cliff.

Before you stumble

Do not spend the hour on the devotion's question about why He had to become man. If it arises, one sentence from week 10 is enough: only a true man can represent us, and only God can bring us all the way to God. He is both. Then return to Hebrews 7. "Ransom for all" in 1 Timothy 2:6 has the same shape as week 14: one Mediator for humanity, received by those who come. Do not reopen a long debate.

WITH STUDENTS

Ask who they text when they need an adult to talk to another adult for them. Then ask what is better about a mediator who never dies and is never annoyed.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Job 9:32–33. Job longs for an arbiter who can lay his hand on both. Then read 1 Timothy 2:5 as the answer Job did not have yet.

Redemption



A standing man places the price into open hands. Someone kneels, no longer clutching what he owed. Freedom here has a receipt.

Before you gather

- Read Day 17, Redemption, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read 1 Peter 1:18–19 and Mark 10:45 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

What is something you were glad to be done with — a loan, a chore, a season — because somebody else finished it?

Leader. Done-ness. Avoid the book's "greatest debt you ever owed" prompt. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Redemption is not God changing His mind for free in the sense of cheap. It is release because a price was paid. The kneeling man is not bargaining. He is receiving a freedom someone else purchased.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Redemption is God's gracious act of purchasing and freeing His people from slavery to sin, death, and judgment through the payment of Christ's blood, securing their release and restoration to Him.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek *apolytrōsis* — a release secured by the payment of a ransom.

MEMORY VERSE • EPHESIANS 1:7

In him we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of our trespasses, according to the riches of his grace.

Together, open the flashcard for Redemption. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 • OPEN THE BIBLE • 15 MIN

1 Peter 1:18–19 and Mark 10:45

The devotion already walked Ruth and the line “free, but not cheap.” Peter names the currency. Mark names the mission. Read both. They are short.

You were ransomed from the futile ways inherited from your forefathers, not with perishable things such as silver or gold, but with the precious blood of Christ, like that of a lamb without blemish or spot. For even the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. What were they ransomed from, and what was not valuable enough to pay it? CORE

Leader. Futile inherited ways. Silver and gold cannot do it. The price is Christ’s blood, lamb-like, unblemished.

2. Mark 10:45 says He came to serve and to give His life as a ransom “for many.” What kind of exchange is that?

Leader. His life for their slavery. A ransom is paid to set captives free. This is purchase, not advice.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Ephesians 1:7 ties redemption to forgiveness “according to the riches of his grace.” If the price is blood, why does Paul still call the purchase grace? CORE

Leader. Costly to Christ, free to us. Grace is not the absence of a price. It is the presence of a Payer who is not you.

4. 1 Corinthians 6:19–20: you were bought with a price, so glorify God in your body. How does being bought change ownership, not only feelings?

Leader. Redemption transfers the title. The question is no longer “what do I feel like doing with myself?”

5. What futile way, inherited from family or culture, still acts like it owns a Christian? What would it mean to live as someone whose ransom has already cleared?

Leader. Patterns: anger, image, money, a family script. Be gentle. Ownership by Christ is freedom, not a new slavery to the group's opinions.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Redemption means Jesus paid with His blood to free us from slavery to sin and bring us back to God.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Thank Christ for a price silver could not touch.
2. Name a futile way you want to stop obeying.
3. Pray for someone still living as if they were unbought.

Before you stumble

Do not turn “bought” into “God owns me so the church can control me.” The Owner is Christ. Also skip any pressure to disclose financial shame or family dysfunction in detail. The text is enough. If Ruth comes up because they read it, affirm it in a sentence — a kinsman pays, the vulnerable are brought home — and stay with Peter.

WITH STUDENTS

Ask what they think they owe to be accepted on a team, in a friend group, online. Then ask which of those currencies Peter says cannot ransom a soul.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Titus 2:14. He gave Himself to redeem us from lawlessness and to purify a people. Redemption has a people, not only a transaction.

Reconciliation



A wall has been broken open. Rubble on both sides, light pouring through the gap. Peace here is not a feeling that the wall was never real. The wall came down.

Before you gather

- Read Day 18, Reconciliation, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Ephesians 2:13–18 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

What is a small wall people build without noticing — a closed door, a group text, a seat saved, a silence?

Leader. Ordinary walls. Do not ask them to retell a resolved conflict and how it felt. That is the journal question. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Sin did not make God distant in a vague way. It made enemies.

Reconciliation is God ending the war by the blood of the cross and opening a way through the wall. We do not climb it. He breaches it.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Reconciliation is God ending the war and separation our sin created by the blood of His Son, Jesus Christ, and granting us lasting peace with Himself.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek katallagē — a change from enmity to friendship. Also eirēnē — peace.

MEMORY VERSE • COLOSSIANS 1:19–20

For in him all the fullness of God was pleased to dwell, and through him to reconcile to himself all things, whether on earth or in heaven, making peace by the blood of his cross.

Together, open the flashcard for Reconciliation. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 • OPEN THE BIBLE • 15 MIN

Ephesians 2:13–18

Romans 5:10 was the devotion's reading. Ephesians 2 is the wall in the drawing: hostility between people, and between us and God, broken by one cross.

But now in Christ Jesus you who once were far off have been brought near by the blood of Christ. For he himself is our peace, who has made us both one and has broken down in his flesh the dividing wall of hostility by abolishing the law of commandments expressed in ordinances, that he might create in himself one new man in place of the two, so making peace, and might reconcile us both to God in one body through the cross, thereby killing the hostility. And he came and preached peace to you who were far off and peace to those who were near.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. What did the wall divide, and what, specifically, tore it down? CORE

Leader. Jew and Gentile, and both from God. The wall comes down in His flesh, by the cross, not by the groups deciding to be mature.

2. Paul says Christ "himself is our peace." How is that different from Christ giving us some advice about peace?

Leader. Peace is a Person we are brought into, not a technique we master. Nearness is "by the blood."

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Colossians 1:21–22, if you read it, remembers that we were hostile in mind. What does reconciled peace with God make possible that a truce would not? CORE

Leader. A truce pauses the shooting. Reconciliation changes the relationship: holy, without blemish, welcomed. God is not barely tolerating His people.

4. The same cross reconciles us to God and to one another. Where is our church still living as if a wall Christ killed were still load-bearing?

Leader. Race, class, age, politics, old offenses. Be concrete and local. Do not let this become a speech. Ask what obedience would look like this month.

5. 2 Corinthians 5:18–20: reconciled people are given the message of reconciliation. If peace has already been made from God’s side, what are we actually asking a friend to do?

Leader. Not to appease an angry deity with gifts. To receive a peace already accomplished, and to come home. Ambassadors announce terms. They do not invent them.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Reconciliation means God ended the war our sin started, through the blood of the cross, and brought us near.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Thank Christ, who is our peace.
2. Confess a wall you have maintained.
3. Pray for one relationship, and for one person still far off.

Before you stumble

“All things” in Colossians 1:20 is not universalism. Paul has just said reconciliation comes by the cross, and the next verses call people to continue in the faith. Enemies are made friends through Christ, not apart from Him. If the room wants the horizontal peace (people with people) without the vertical (people with God), Ephesians will not allow it. The cross does both, in that order.

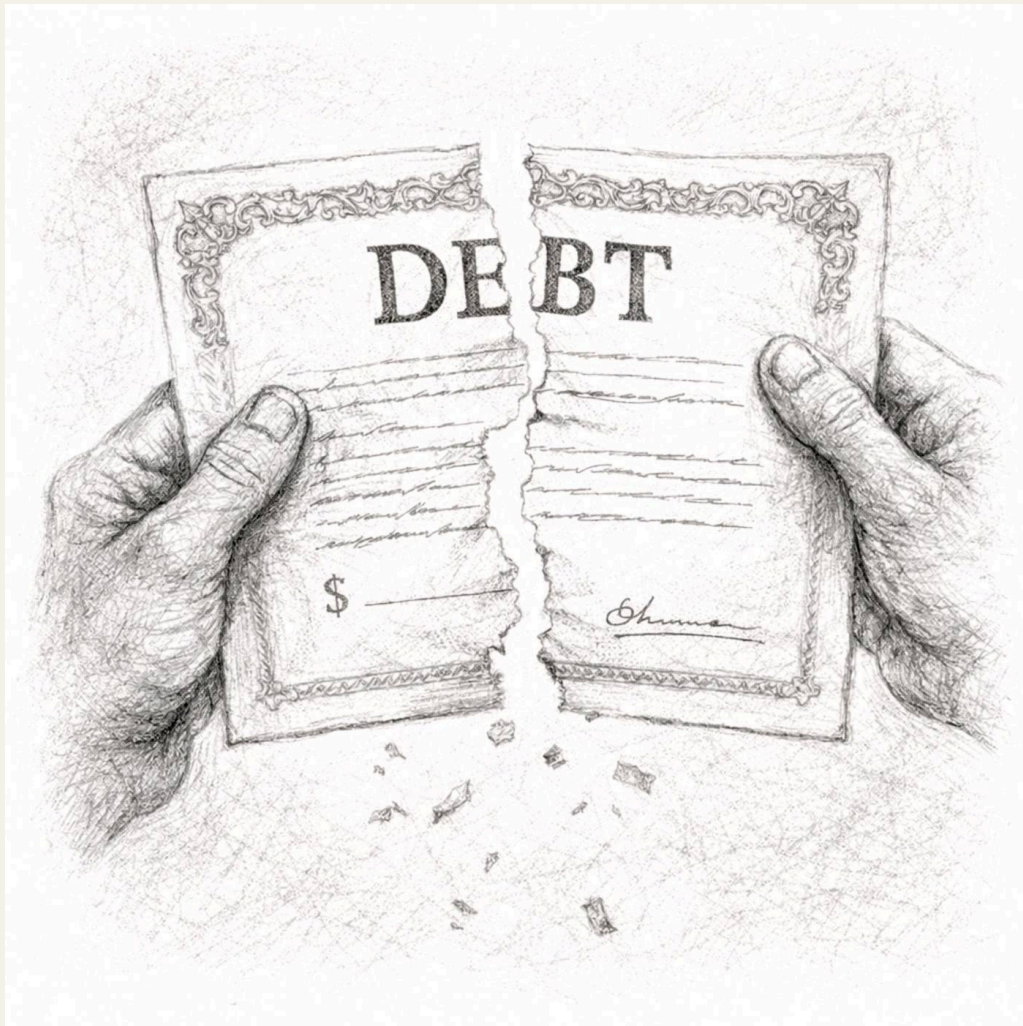
WITH STUDENTS

Ask which hallway at their school has an invisible wall. Then ask what it would mean that Jesus, not a program, is the one who can actually kill hostility. Keep it from becoming a rant about other students.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Romans 5:1 and 5:10–11, only if you need the word “enemies” said plainly. Do not camp there. They reflected on 5:10 already.

Forgiveness



Two hands tear a sheet that says DEBT. The rip is down the middle. Scraps fall. Forgiveness is not a payment plan. The paper does not get taped back together.

Before you gather

- Read Day 19, Forgiveness, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Luke 7:41–48 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

Open the room

What is a notification, a bill, or a reminder you would love to see disappear and never reload?

Leader. Ordinary relief. Do not ask how God's forgiveness differs from ours. That was the journal. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Look at the tear. God does not file the debt in a drawer for later. In Christ He cancels it. Forgiveness is release — the word means the debt is let go — because Jesus already paid.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Forgiveness is the gracious act of God by which He fully pardons sinners of their guilt, cancels their debt of sin, and no longer holds their transgressions against them because of Christ's work on the cross.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek aphasis — release, pardon, the cancellation of a debt.

MEMORY VERSE • COLOSSIANS 1:14

In whom we have redemption, the forgiveness of sins.

Together, open the flashcard for Forgiveness. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

Luke 7:41–48

Psalms 103:12 was their reflection text. Luke 7 puts two debts, a table, and Jesus' own words in the room. Read the short parable and the verdict, not the whole chapter,

unless you have time.

"A certain moneylender had two debtors. One owed five hundred denarii, and the other fifty. When they could not pay, he cancelled the debt of both. Now which of them will love him more?" Simon answered, "The one, I suppose, for whom he cancelled the larger debt." And he said to him, "You have judged rightly." ... And he said to her, "Your sins are forgiven." Then those who were at table with him began to say among themselves, "Who is this, who even forgives sins?" And he said to the woman, "Your faith has saved you; go in peace."

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. Both debtors are cancelled, not just the smaller one. What made the difference in their love, according to Jesus? **CORE**

Leader. They both couldn't pay. The one who knows the size of the cancellation loves more. Forgiveness is the same act. Awareness differs.

2. The table guests ask, "Who is this, who even forgives sins?" Why is that the right question?

Leader. Only the one who holds the debt can cancel it. Jesus is acting as God, not as a therapist who helps her move on.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Micah 7:18–19: God pardons iniquity and casts sin into the depths of the sea. What do we do with a sin we believe God forgave but we keep retrieving? **CORE**

Leader. Retrieving is unbelief dressed as seriousness. The sea is not a filing cabinet. Be pastoral, not scolding.

4. Ephesians 4:32: forgive one another, as God in Christ forgave you. The standard is not "when they deserve it." Where are you offering a payment plan to someone Christ

already taught you how to release?

Leader. This is not “pretend it didn’t happen.” Cancellation can include truth-telling and boundaries. It cannot include a private ledger you mean to collect.

5. Colossians 1:14 puts redemption and forgiveness in the same breath. Why is “I forgive myself” a thinner sentence than “In Christ we have forgiveness”?

Leader. You are not the lender. Self-forgiveness language often skips the cross. The release comes from the One who was owed.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Forgiveness means God cancels our debt of sin in Christ and does not hold it against us.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Thank God for a torn record.
2. Confess a sin you keep fishing out of the sea.
3. Ask for strength to tear up a ledger you have kept on someone else. Silently is fine.

Before you stumble

Do not pressure abuse victims to reconcile with someone dangerous. Forgiveness is releasing vengeance to God. It is not the same as restoring access. Say that if the conversation goes near family harm. Also, Jesus ties great love to a known cancellation. People who feel little may need a clearer look at the debt, not a scolding for being unemotional.

WITH STUDENTS

Ask what “we’re good” means after a friend blows up at them. Usually it means “I’ll remember this.” Contrast that with a torn page. Then ask which one sounds like God in Christ.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Isaiah 43:25. “I will not remember your sins.” God is not forgetful. He chooses not to bring them up as charges. Useful if someone fears God’s memory.

Covenant



A bride and groom face each other under a flowering arch, hands held. Vows, not a handshake deal. Joy, and a bond that is meant to hold.

OPTIONAL, THREE MINUTES

Optional, before the icebreaker: Which word from Part III — incarnation through covenant — do you least want to forget, and why? One sentence each, no speeches. Then open Genesis 15.

Before you gather

- Read Day 20, Covenant, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Genesis 15:7–18 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

What is a promise someone kept long after it stopped being convenient?

Leader. Kept promises. Do not ask them to map wedding vows onto Hebrews 13:5. They did that reflection already. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: A covenant is God binding Himself to a people with promises. It is closer to vows than to a contract we negotiate as equals. The new covenant stands because a death has occurred. Jesus is the Mediator of it, and the inheritance is for those who are called.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

A covenant is a divinely established, binding relationship in which God commits Himself to His people with promises and often confirms it with signs and blood.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek *diathēkē* — a covenant, a binding commitment, a testament.

MEMORY VERSE • HEBREWS 9:15

Therefore he is the mediator of a new covenant, so that those who are called may receive the promised eternal inheritance, since a death has

occurred that redeems them from the transgressions committed under the first covenant.

Together, open the flashcard for Covenant. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 · OPEN THE BIBLE · 15 MIN

Genesis 15:7–18

God makes a covenant with Abram by walking the aisle of cut animals alone, as a smoking fire pot and a flaming torch, while Abram is in a deep sleep. The devotion used the wedding picture devotionally. This text shows who carries the oath.

And he said to him, "I am the LORD who brought you out from Ur of the Chaldeans to give you this land to possess." ... "Know for certain that your offspring will be sojourners... and they shall come back here." When the sun had gone down and it was dark, behold, a smoking fire pot and a flaming torch passed between the pieces. On that day the LORD made a covenant with Abram, saying, "To your offspring I give this land."

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. In the ancient ceremony, both parties normally walked between the pieces, taking the curse on themselves if they broke faith. Who walks in this story? Where is Abram?

CORE

Leader. God, pictured as fire, walks alone. Abram is asleep. The covenant's certainty rests on God's oath, not Abram's performance that night.

2. God tells Abram the future, including hard years, "for certain." What kind of promise can talk that honestly about suffering and still be good?

Leader. A sovereign promise. Covenant is not a guarantee that the path will be easy. It is a guarantee that God will do what He said.

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Jeremiah 31:33–34: God will write His law on hearts, be their God, and remember their sin no more. Which of those three promises do you live as if He might withdraw?

CORE

Leader. Usually the third, sometimes the first. The new covenant is God's "I will," not our "we might."

4. Hebrews 9:15 says a death redeems transgressions committed under the first covenant, so the called receive an eternal inheritance. Why was a new covenant needed at all if the old one already had sacrifices?

Leader. The old exposed sin and pointed forward. It could not finally clear the conscience or secure an eternal inheritance. Christ's death does. Hebrews 8–10 if someone wants more later.

5. The drawing is a wedding. Ephesians 5:25–27 says Christ loved the church and gave Himself up for her. What do marriage vows teach about covenant that a contract does not — and where does the analogy break?

Leader. Vows are personal, exclusive, and lasting. The analogy breaks where we are equal partners earning the relationship. We are the bride He washed. He is not lucky to have us.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

A covenant is God binding Himself to His people by promise, and the new covenant stands because Jesus died.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · PRAY · 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Praise God for promises that do not depend on our staying awake.
2. Ask Him to write His ways on a place in you that still bargains.
3. Pray for the marriages and the single people in the room to trust Christ's vow more than their own.

Before you stumble

Part III ends with this word. Do not imply every Old Testament covenant had the same terms. Abraham's covenant here is pure promise. Sinai will include commands. The new covenant fulfills both: law on the heart, and a death that secures the inheritance. If the room is new, you do not need that taxonomy. You need: God commits Himself, and Jesus' blood is why we inherit. End by previewing Part IV in two sentences: the Spirit is how this covenant gets inside a person.

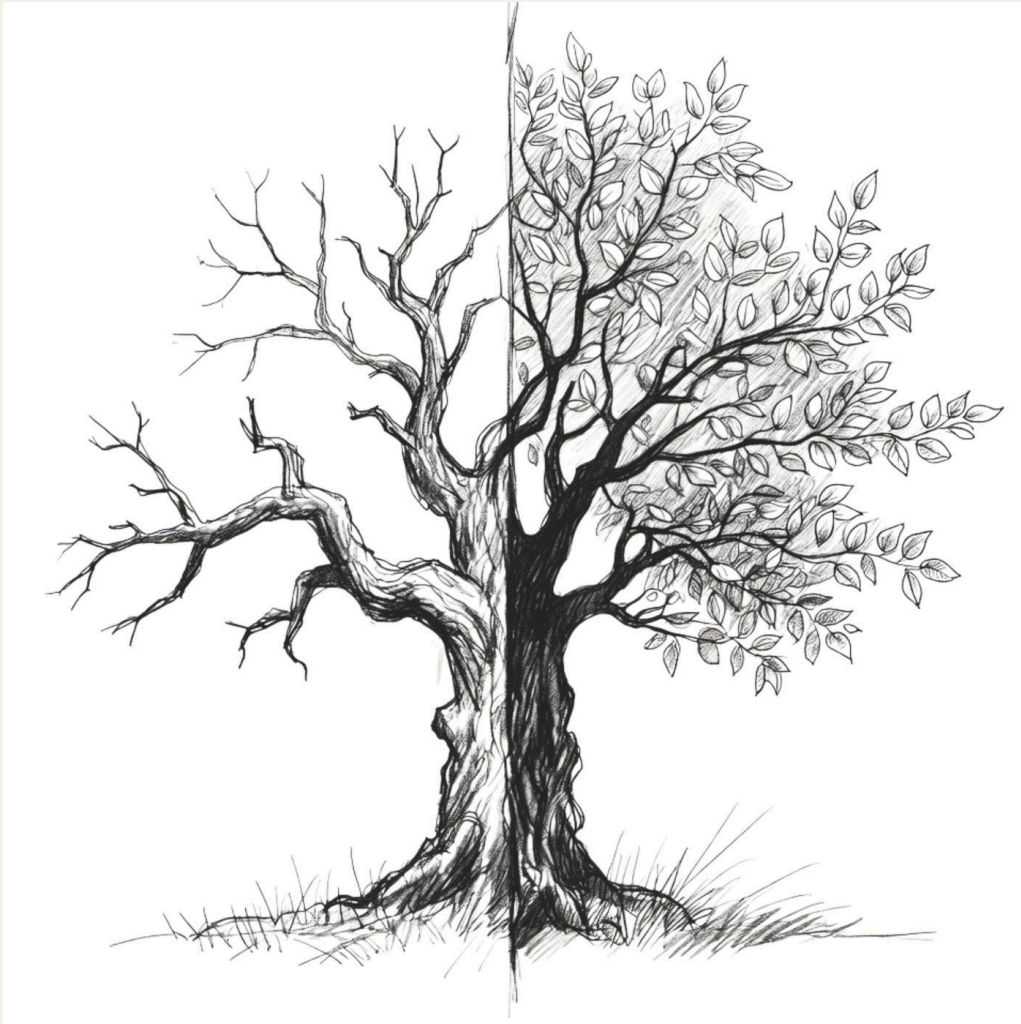
WITH STUDENTS

Ask what happens to a group project when only one person is reliable. Then ask why it is good news that God walked the aisle alone. Keep the wedding talk dignified, not joke-driven.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Luke 22:20. "This cup... is the new covenant in my blood." If you celebrate the Lord's Supper soon, connect it. If not, simply read the line.

Regeneration



One tree, split down the trunk. Dead wood on one side, leaves on the other. Same roots, two conditions. The life is not a coat of paint on the dead half.

OPEN PART IV BY SAYING

Christ's work is finished. It is not automatic wallpaper. The Spirit gives life, marks, adopts, delivers, and brings people to faith and repentance, then keeps making them like Jesus. These weeks are about how the news becomes a person.

Before you gather

- Read Day 21, Regeneration, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read John 3:3–8 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

1 · ICEBREAKER · 7 MIN

Open the room

What is something you noticed was alive only because you had seen it dead — a plant, a neighborhood, a friendship, a field in spring?

Leader. Contrast, not their conversion story. The book already asked what changed when they came alive. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 · THE WORD · 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: This is not a tree that tried harder. God makes the dead live. Regeneration is the Spirit's work of new birth. You do not achieve it. You wake up in it.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Regeneration is being born again through the Holy Spirit. It is a supernatural work of God in which a spiritually dead person is made alive.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek palingenesia — rebirth, regeneration. Also zōopoieō — to make alive.

MEMORY VERSE · TITUS 3:5

He saved us, not because of works done by us in righteousness, but according to his own mercy, by the washing of regeneration and renewal of the Holy Spirit.

Together, open the flashcard for Regeneration. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

John 3:3–8

Second Corinthians 5:17 was the reflection text, with its put-off and put-on.

Nicodemus hears that entering the kingdom requires a birth from above, and that the Spirit is as free as wind.

Jesus answered him, "Truly, truly, I say to you, unless one is born again he cannot see the kingdom of God." Nicodemus said to him, "How can a man be born when he is old?" ... Jesus answered, "Truly, truly, I say to you, unless one is born of water and the Spirit, he cannot enter the kingdom of God. That which is born of the flesh is flesh, and that which is born of the Spirit is spirit. Do not marvel that I said to you, 'You must be born again.' The wind blows where it wishes, and you hear its sound, but you do not know where it comes from or where it goes. So it is with everyone who is born of the Spirit."

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. Nicodemus is a serious religious teacher. What, according to Jesus, can he still not do unless he is born again? **CORE**

Leader. See and enter the kingdom. Religion without new birth leaves him outside. This humbles the competent.

2. Jesus compares the Spirit to wind. What can you tell about the wind, and what can you not control?

Leader. You hear the sound and see the effects. You do not steer the Spirit. New birth is God's act. The effects are visible later.

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Ezekiel 36:26–27 promises a new heart and God's Spirit, causing people to walk in His ways. How is that different from deciding to be a better version of the old heart?

CORE

Leader. The material changes. God does not motivate the dead half of the tree. He gives life. Obedience follows the new heart. It does not create it.

4. Titus 3:5 says the washing of regeneration is mercy, not works done by us in righteousness. What “works done in righteousness” do people still offer as the reason God made them alive?

Leader. A prayer prayed well, a raised hand, a moral cleanup before believing. Those may accompany. They do not cause.

5. John 3:8 says you hear the sound. What is the sound of new birth in an ordinary week — not a spectacular story, a real one?

Leader. New desires, a conscience that wakes up, love for a people you used to avoid, hunger for the word. Affirm quiet stories. Do not rank them against dramatic ones.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Regeneration means the Holy Spirit makes a dead person alive. It is new birth, and it is God’s work.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Thank the Spirit for any true life in the room.
2. Pray for someone who is still only the dead half of the tree.
3. Ask that the sound of new life would be obvious in this group without becoming a performance.

Before you stumble

Read the Part IV opener. “Born of water and the Spirit” has been argued for centuries. Do not spend the night on baptismal theology unless your church needs a one-sentence note: Jesus is talking about a cleansing new birth the Spirit gives, which baptism later signifies, not a ritual that replaces the Spirit. If you are unsure, say “Let’s not settle that side question tonight” and stay on the necessity and the freedom of the new birth. Also: do not tell a depressed person they are spiritually dead because they feel flat. Ask about Christ, not about mood.

WITH STUDENTS

Nicodemus thought being an insider was enough. Ask what insider status students trust: Christian school, parents’ faith, camp, a moral reputation. Then read verse 3 again.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

1 Peter 1:3 and 1:23. Born again to a living hope, through the living word. A good bridge back to mercy and forward to the Bible they are holding.

Sealing



A wax seal, crest pressed in, ribbon hanging, on a written document. The seal says: this is real, this is official, this is not yours to break.

Before you gather

- Read Day 22, Sealing, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Ephesians 4:30 and 2 Corinthians 1:21–22 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

What object in your life proves something is yours — a key, a title, a ring, a signature, a stamp?

Leader. Proof of ownership. The book already asked how sealing helps them feel safe, and it used Philippians 1:6. Do not repeat those. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: A seal is not a decoration. It marks ownership and says the contents stand. God seals believers with the Holy Spirit when they believe the gospel. You are not held by your grip. You are marked by His.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Sealing is the divine act by which the Holy Spirit marks believers as God's own possession, guarantees their future inheritance, and secures them for salvation.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek sphragizō — to seal, to mark with a sign of ownership and authenticity.

MEMORY VERSE • EPHESIANS 1:13

In him you also, when you heard the word of truth, the gospel of your salvation, and believed in him, were sealed with the promised Holy Spirit.

Together, open the flashcard for Sealing. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 • OPEN THE BIBLE • 15 MIN

Ephesians 4:30 and 2 Corinthians 1:21–22

Ephesians 1:13 is the memory verse. These two short texts show what the seal means on a bad day: do not grieve the Spirit who sealed you, and God is the one who establishes you.

And do not grieve the Holy Spirit of God, by whom you were sealed for the day of redemption. And it is God who establishes us with you in Christ, and has anointed us, and who has also put his seal on us and given us his Spirit in our hearts as a guarantee.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. You can grieve the Spirit. Can you, according to these verses, unseal yourself? What was the seal for? **CORE**

Leader. Grief is real. The seal was for the day of redemption. Sin saddens the Spirit. It does not dissolve the mark. This is the distinction the night needs.

2. Who establishes, anoints, and seals in 2 Corinthians 1? What is the Spirit called besides a seal?

Leader. God does it. The Spirit is a guarantee — a down payment. The future inheritance has already put money down in the heart.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Ephesians 1:13 puts the seal after hearing and believing. What does that order protect us from? What does it not mean?

Leader. It protects us from claiming the seal with no gospel faith. It does not mean the Spirit was absent from drawing us. Don't build a minute-by-minute ordo. Do insist the seal belongs to believers.

4. A seal can be broken by someone stronger than the one who set it. Read John 10:28–29 beside the wax. Who would have to be overpowered for you to be unsealed?

CORE

Leader. The Father, who is greater than all. Assurance is only as strong as the Sealer. That is the point.

5. If grieving the Spirit is possible for a sealed person, what is a real way this group could grieve Him together — and what would honoring the seal look like instead?

Leader. Gossip, contempt, lying, using people. Honoring looks like truth, tenderness, and not treating the mark as permission. Ephesians 4:25–32 is the neighborhood of the verse.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Sealing means the Holy Spirit marks believers as God's own and guarantees He will bring them to the end.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Thank the Spirit for being both the seal and the guarantee.
2. Confess a way you have grieved Him as if the mark made obedience optional.
3. Pray for someone who is afraid they have undone their salvation.

Before you stumble

Do not say “once saved, always saved” in a careless way that means “sin freely.” Say what the text says: God seals believers for the day of redemption, and He commands them not to grieve the Spirit. If someone is in open rebellion and claims the seal as a shield, Ephesians 4 is a warning, not a lullaby. If someone is tender and scared, John 10 is the word. Know which person you are talking to.

WITH STUDENTS

Compare a school stamp on a form with a parent's signature that actually holds. Ask which one God is like in this text, and what the day of redemption is the deadline for.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Romans 8:15–16. The Spirit bears witness that we are children. Use it if assurance, not grief, is the real question in the room. Adoption is next week either way.

Adoption



A judge speaks from the bench, glad. A family gathers a child in — father, mother, son — faces up, unashamed. The law and the hug are both in the frame.

Before you gather

- Read Day 23, Adoption, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Galatians 4:4–7 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

Open the room

What is a place you did not start out belonging, where someone eventually made a place for you?

Leader. Being brought in. The book already asked about belonging, church conflict, and loneliness. Stay out of those three prompts. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Adoption is not God pretending you were always fine. It is a legal welcome into His family, through Jesus, because He wanted you. Rights, a name, an inheritance, and a Father who is glad.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Adoption means God welcomes believers into His family as dear children, giving us full rights and love as heirs in Christ.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek huiothesia — placement as a son, the legal act of adoption.

MEMORY VERSE • EPHESIANS 1:4–5

In love he predestined us for adoption to himself as sons through Jesus Christ, according to the purpose of his will.

Together, open the flashcard for Adoption. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

Galatians 4:4–7

Paul moves a person from slave to son to heir, and puts “Abba, Father” in their mouth. That is the doctrine in one paragraph, and it is not the journal assignment.

But when the fullness of time had come, God sent forth his Son, born of woman, born under the law, to redeem those who were under the law, so that we might receive adoption as sons. And because you are sons, God has sent the Spirit of his Son into our hearts, crying, “Abba! Father!” So you are no longer a slave, but a son, and if a son, then an heir through God.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. Trace the sequence: what did the Son do, what do we receive, and what does the Spirit cry? **CORE**

Leader. Born under the law, He redeems. We receive adoption. The Spirit cries Abba. Sonship is not a mood. It follows redemption and comes with the Spirit.

2. What is the difference, in verse 7, between a slave in the house and a son?

Leader. A slave may work on the property. A son inherits it. Duty without adoption is not the gospel.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Romans 8:15–17 says the Spirit does not lead us back into fear, and that children are heirs — heirs with Christ, provided we suffer with Him. How does adoption speak to fear, and why does Paul refuse to separate sonship from sharing Christ’s sufferings?

CORE

Leader. Abba answers fear. Glory later includes suffering now. Adoption is not a promise that the family avoids pain. It is a promise you do not face it as an orphan.

4. Ephesians 1:5 says this was “according to the purpose of his will,” in love. What happens to assurance if we think we were adopted because we were the promising kid?

Leader. The purpose was His. The love was His. Promising kids burn out trying to stay adoptable.

5. John 1:12–13: he gave the right to become children of God to those who received Him, born not of the will of the flesh. Who in your actual life still thinks they have to earn a seat at a father’s table — maybe even yours?

Leader. A child, a friend, a new believer. Ask what a word of welcome would sound like that does not add a condition Christ did not add.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

Adoption means God receives believers as His own children and heirs, through Jesus, because He loves them.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · PRAY · 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Pray the word Abba slowly. Let it be awkward if it is awkward.
2. Thank Him that you are not staff in the house.
3. Pray for someone who only knows fathers as fear.

Before you stumble

The courtroom drawing can hurt someone whose adoption or family story is complicated. Say at the outset: this doctrine does not depend on your earthly parents being a good parable. God is the Father Jesus trusted, not a magnification of a wound. “Sons” in Galatians 4 is legal status for every believer, women and men. Daughters are not second-tier. The word is about the rights of the heir. Say so. Do not force anyone to share a family story.

WITH STUDENTS

Ask what a last name does at school, on a jersey, on a form. Then ask what it would mean that God put His name on them before they performed.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Luke 15:22–24, the robe, the ring, and the feast. You used the embrace in week 2. Here, notice the signs of sonship restored. Two minutes, if you want a picture.

Rescue



A firefighter carries a man out of a burning room. The rescued man cannot walk himself out. The rescuer went in on purpose.

Before you gather

- Read Day 24, Rescue, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Mark 2:1–12 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

Who would you call first if something in your house caught fire, and why them?

Leader. A name and a reason: near, able, willing. Do not ask people to narrate a trauma or the threats God rescued them from. That is the book's question. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Rescue is personal. Jesus does not shout instructions into a burning house. He enters the darkness and transfers people into His kingdom. Deliverance is a change of address, not only a change of mood.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Rescue, or deliverance, is God saving people from danger, freeing them from sin, evil, and judgment, both now and forever through Jesus.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek *rhuomai* — to rescue, to deliver, to draw someone out of danger.

MEMORY VERSE • COLOSSIANS 1:13

He has delivered us from the domain of darkness and transferred us to the kingdom of his beloved Son.

Together, open the flashcard for Rescue. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 • OPEN THE BIBLE • 15 MIN

Mark 2:1–12

Friends tear open a roof because a man cannot get himself to Jesus. Jesus delivers him from sin and, then, from the stretcher. The devotion sent them to pray for someone in darkness. This story asks what kind of deliverance Jesus leads with.

And they came, bringing to him a paralytic carried by four men. And when they could not get near him because of the crowd, they removed the roof above him, and when they had made an opening, they let down the bed... And when Jesus saw their faith, he said to the paralytic, "Son, your sins are forgiven." ... "But that you may know that the Son of Man has authority on earth to forgive sins" — he said to the paralytic — "I say to you, rise, pick up your bed, and go home." And he rose and immediately picked up his bed and went out before them all.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. What did the friends expect, as far as we can tell, and what did Jesus give first?

CORE

Leader. They brought a body. He forgave sins first, then raised the man. The deepest rescue is the kingdom transfer, not only the symptom.

2. How did the man get into the room? What does that show about his ability, and about theirs?

Leader. He was carried. Other people can bring you to Jesus. They cannot be Jesus. Faith, here, is even visible in the friends.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Colossians 1:13 says delivered from a domain and transferred into a kingdom. A domain is a government. What still acts like it governs a Christian whom Jesus has already moved? CORE

Leader. Shame, a habit, an old crowd, despair, the approval of people. Transfer means a new King. The old one does not get a spare key.

4. Psalm 40:1–2: He drew me up from the pit and set my feet on a rock. Rescue in that psalm includes waiting. Why is waiting not the same thing as God failing to come in?

Leader. The firefighter’s timeline and ours often differ. Waiting is part of many deliverances. It is not proof you are still in the old kingdom.

5. The four friends made a hole in someone else’s roof. What is a costly, practical way this group could carry someone toward Jesus without trying to be their savior?

Leader. A ride, a meal, sitting with them in a service, a conversation that actually names Christ. Costly and specific. Not “we should love people more.”

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Rescue means Jesus delivers people out of the dominion of darkness and brings them into His kingdom.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Thank Him for coming into the fire.
2. Pray for someone you would carry to Jesus if you could get them through the roof.
3. Ask for freedom where an old domain still gives orders.

Before you stumble

The drawing is intense, and the book mentions real evil, including trafficking. Do not ask anyone to describe abuse, violence, or a rescue story. Say: “You do not owe this room your worst day.” If someone discloses harm, believe them, stop the group from fixing it in public, and follow up privately with real help. Theologically:

deliverance from darkness is first forgiveness and a new King. Jesus does heal bodies. Do not promise a stretcher outcome on your timetable, and do not treat ongoing suffering as weak faith.

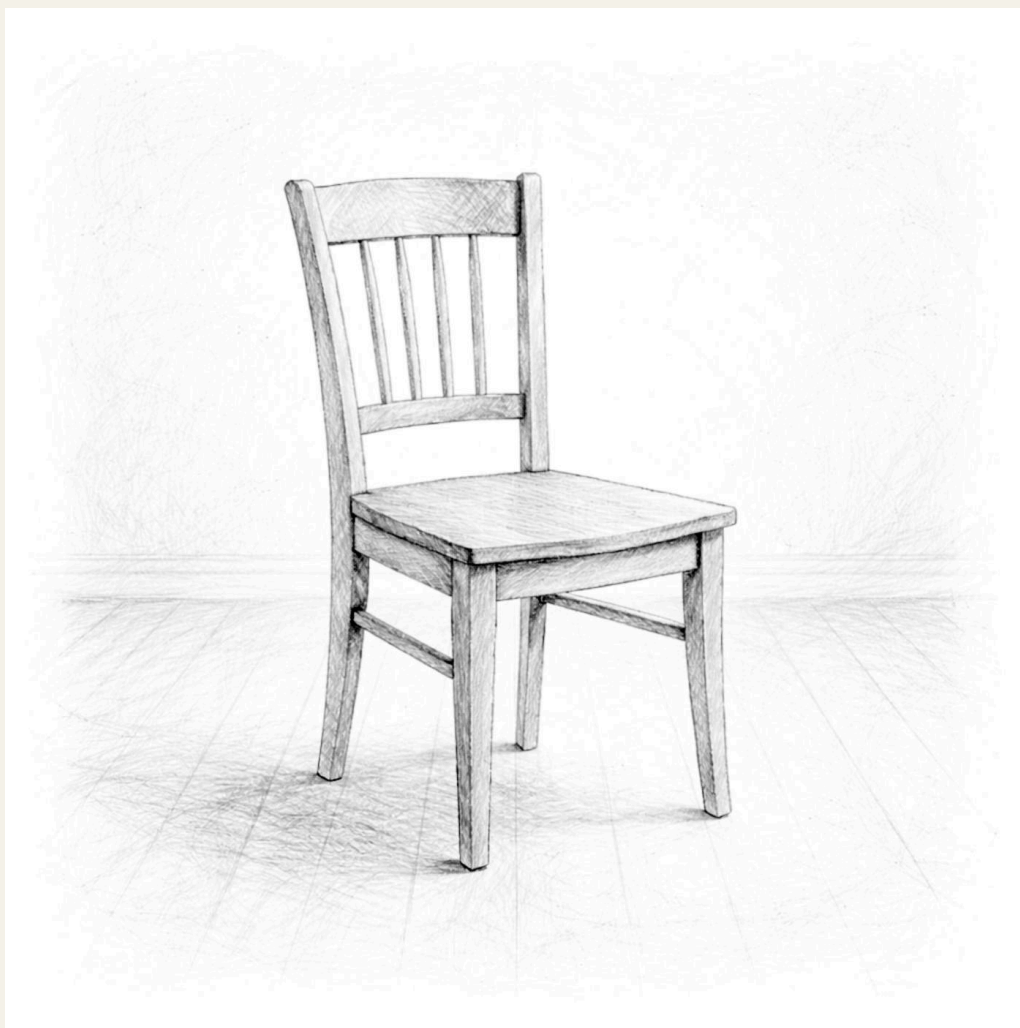
WITH STUDENTS

Ask what “carrying a friend” looks like when the friend does not want church. Honor courage. Forbid cruelty and gossip disguised as concern.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Acts 26:17–18. Jesus sends Paul to open eyes, so people turn from darkness to light and receive forgiveness. Mission is rescue work under His authority.

Faith



An empty wooden chair in a quiet room. It does not save anyone as furniture. It saves no one until a person sits and lets it hold them.

Before you gather

- Read Day 25, Faith, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Genesis 15:1–6 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

Where do you hate to let someone else drive, carry the tray, or hold the ladder — and what are you afraid they will do?

Leader. Control. The book asked where they rely on works and what steps would deepen reliance. You are only opening the theme of weight. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Faith is not standing beside the chair and agreeing that chairs are strong. Faith sits down. It is relying on Jesus instead of on yourself — your grip, your record, your feelings about your grip.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Faith is trusting Jesus alone to save you and relying on Him instead of yourself.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek *pistis* — faith, trust, reliance, a confidence that rests its weight on another.

MEMORY VERSE • ROMANS 5:1

Therefore, since we have been justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ.

Together, open the flashcard for Faith. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 • OPEN THE BIBLE • 15 MIN

Genesis 15:1–6

Abraham is old, childless, and asked to trust a promise he cannot perform. God calls the belief righteousness. Romans 4 will preach this text. Stay in the narrative first.

After these things the word of the LORD came to Abram in a vision: "Fear not, Abram, I am your shield; your reward shall be very great." But Abram said, "O Lord GOD, what will you give me, for I continue childless..." And behold, the word of the LORD came to him: "This man shall not be your heir; your very own son shall be your heir." And he brought him outside and said, "Look toward heaven, and number the stars, if you are able to number them." Then he said to him, "So shall your offspring be." And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. What is Abram unable to produce, and what does God tell him to look at? **CORE**

Leader. An heir. The stars. God moves his eyes off his body and onto the promise. Faith looks where God points.

2. Verse 6 is famous. What, exactly, is counted to Abram as righteousness — a great deed, or believing God?

Leader. Believing the Lord. Before circumcision, before Isaac, before the law. This is why Paul loves the verse.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Romans 4:4–5 uses this story to say God justifies the ungodly who do not work but believe. How is sitting in the chair different from inspecting the chair, complimenting the chair, or holding yourself up while you touch it? **CORE**

Leader. Agreement is not reliance. Many church people inspect Jesus for years. Faith puts weight on Him.

4. Matthew 11:28–30: "Come to me... and I will give you rest." Jesus offers a yoke, not a couch with no Lord. How can rest and obedience fit in the same faith?

Leader. You rest from self-salvation and take His yoke. Faith is not passivity about holiness. It is passivity about earning, and activity about following.

5. James 2:17 says faith by itself, if it does not work, is dead. Does that cancel Romans 5:1? What is a dead “faith,” and what is a living one?

Leader. James is describing a chair nobody sits in — a claim with no reliance and no fruit. Paul is describing the sitting that justifies. They are not two ways to be saved. Fruit shows the seat was taken. Do not let a debate replace that sentence.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Faith is trusting Jesus alone to save you — sitting down, and letting Him hold your weight.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Tell God, simply, where you are still holding yourself up.
2. Thank Him for counting belief as righteousness.
3. Ask for a living faith that rests and follows.

Before you stumble

Some in the room may realize they have inspected the chair for years. Give them a clear, unpressured way to sit down: turn from self-reliance and trust Christ. Do not force a public ritual unless that is your church’s normal care for a person. Follow up. Also, Abram’s faith later wobbles (Genesis 16). Counted righteousness does not mean flawless trust every month. Say that so parents of wavering kids can breathe.

WITH STUDENTS

Have everyone physically notice the chair they are sitting on and what it would mean if they refused to put weight on it. Then make the comparison once, cleanly, and do not overwork the object lesson.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

John 6:28–29. The work of God is to believe in the One He sent. Useful when someone asks, “What do I have to do?”

Repentance



A U-turn sign beside a road that was heading the other way. Repentance is not feeling bad in the same lane. The sign is an instruction to turn around.

Before you gather

- Read Day 26, Repentance, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Luke 19:1–10 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

Open the room

When did a wrong turn cost you real time, and how long did you argue with the map before you turned around?

Leader. Delay and pride. Do not ask them to inventory godly sorrow or to attack “easy believism.” Both are the book’s questions. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Jesus’ first sermon puts two words together: repent and believe. A change of direction and a trust in the news. Tears can be real. The sign in the drawing is about the road, not only the feeling.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Repentance is the turning of a sinner away from sin and toward God, involving a change of mind, heart, and direction of life.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek metanoia — a change of mind that turns the whole person.

MEMORY VERSE • MARK 1:15

The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand; repent and believe in the gospel.

Together, open the flashcard for Repentance. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

Luke 19:1–10

Zacchaeus turns in public, in his money, the same day he is welcomed. You can see the U-turn. You are not asking the group to confess a secret sin out loud.

He entered Jericho and was passing through. And behold, there was a man named Zacchaeus. He was a chief tax collector and rich. ... And when Jesus came to the place, he looked up and said to him, "Zacchaeus, hurry and come down, for I must stay at your house today." ... And Zacchaeus stood and said to the Lord, "Behold, Lord, the half of my goods I give to the poor. And if I have defrauded anyone of anything, I restore it fourfold." And Jesus said to him, "Today salvation has come to this house... For the Son of Man came to seek and to save the lost."

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. Who moves first — Zacchaeus climbing, or Jesus calling? What does Zacchaeus do after Jesus comes to the house? **CORE**

Leader. Jesus seeks and calls. Zacchaeus responds with joy and with a costly turn: generosity and restitution. Repentance is response to a Seeker, not a self-improvement project that earns the visit.

2. Jesus calls this "salvation," and He calls Zacchaeus "lost" a moment later, even as a son of Abraham. What was he lost from, if he was already religiously nearby?

Leader. Lost is not only "far from church." A wealthy insider can be lost. Salvation reaches his house, not only his mood.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Mark 1:15 refuses to split repent from believe. What does a so-called faith look like with no U-turn, and what does a turn look like with no gospel to turn toward? **CORE**

Leader. Faith without turning is a claim. Turning without the gospel is moralism or despair. Jesus holds them together.

4. Acts 3:19: repent and turn again, that sins may be blotted out. Acts 26:20: repent and turn, performing deeds in keeping with repentance. Why is restitution, when it is possible, part of a turn and not a way of paying Jesus back?

Leader. Zacchaeus does not purchase salvation. The welcome came first. The money shows the turn is real. Where payback is impossible, the turn still shows up in confession and a new direction.

5. You do not have to name a sin in this circle. What is the shape of a turn — what would have to change direction, not just be regretted — that you already know about?

Leader. Shape, not spectacle: a habit stopped, a person repaid, a lie corrected, a relationship approached differently. Offer silence. Do not go around the circle demanding answers.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

Repentance is a real turn — mind, heart, and direction — away from sin and toward God, joined to faith in the gospel.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · PRAY · 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Thank Jesus for seeking the lost instead of waiting to be found.
2. Ask for a turn, not only a feeling, where you have been delaying.
3. Pray for a house, like Zacchaeus's, that needs salvation to arrive.

Before you stumble

Do not turn the group into a confession booth. Do not embarrass anyone. If someone wants to confess something serious, receive it briefly, thank them, and move the rest offline with care. Repentance is not penance: you are not assigning spiritual punishments. It is also not nothing: "easy" agreement with no direction is not Mark 1:15. Hold both without the book's debate-club tone.

WITH STUDENTS

Ask what a U-turn looks like on a phone: who they stop texting, what they stop watching, who they tell the truth to. Specific beats emotional.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

2 Corinthians 7:8–10, only if someone asks whether sorrow counts. Godly grief produces a turn. Worldly grief produces regret with no road change. They may have read this in the book. Use it as a clarification, not as the main study.

Sanctification



A man pulls a clean robe over a stained shirt, and he is glad to do it. He is not hiding. He is dressing for a new identity that is already his.

Before you gather

- Read Day 27, Sanctification, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Colossians 3:1–4, 12–14 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

What is a piece of clothing, a uniform, or a jacket that changed how you carried yourself when you put it on?

Leader. Identity you wear. Do not ask them to list unholy things to take off. That was the journal response. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Sanctification is both a status and a direction. God has already set His people apart — washed, sanctified, justified — and He is still clothing them in a new way of life. The robe is not a costume to impress strangers. It is who they now are.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Sanctification means God has set you apart as holy and His, and now He is making you more like Jesus.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek *hagiasmos* — holiness, consecration, being set apart as God's.

MEMORY VERSE • 1 CORINTHIANS 6:11

And such were some of you. But you were washed, you were sanctified, you were justified in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ and by the Spirit of our God.

Together, open the flashcard for Sanctification. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 • OPEN THE BIBLE • 15 MIN

Colossians 3:1–4, 12–14

Paul starts with “you have been raised,” then tells them what to put on. The devotion asked them to define positional and progressive sanctification and to commit to taking garments off. You will let the text show the order instead of quizzing the definitions.

If then you have been raised with Christ, seek the things that are above, where Christ is, seated at the right hand of God. Set your minds on things that are above, not on things that are on earth. For you have died, and your life is hidden with Christ in God. When Christ who is your life appears, then you also will appear with him in glory. Put on then, as God’s chosen ones, holy and beloved, compassionate hearts, kindness, humility, meekness, and patience, bearing with one another... And above all these put on love, which binds everything together in perfect harmony.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. What does Paul say is already true of them before he tells them to put anything on?

CORE

Leader. Raised with Christ, died, life hidden with Christ, chosen, holy, beloved. The command lands on people who already have a status. Imperative follows indicative.

2. Look at the wardrobe list in verses 12–14. Are these mostly private feelings, or ways of treating other people?

Leader. Mostly relational: compassion, patience, bearing with, forgiving, love. Holiness shows up in the room, not only in a quiet time.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. 1 Corinthians 6:11 puts washed, sanctified, and justified in the past tense — “such were some of you.” How should a Christian’s past be talked about: erased from honesty, or no longer in charge? CORE

Leader. Paul names the past in the previous verses and then says “were.” Honesty without ownership. The old life is not the name on the robe.

4. Philippians 2:12–13: work out your salvation, for God is at work in you to will and to work. Where do we slide into “God does it, so I will not” or “I do it, so it depends on me”?

Leader. Both slides deny the verse. We work because He works. Effort is not earning. Passivity is not faith.

5. Colossians 3:4 says Christ is your life, and glory is still future. What would change this month if you believed holiness is becoming who you already are in Him, rather than becoming someone God might finally like?

Leader. Fear-based change exhausts people. Identity-based change can tell the truth and still rejoice. Tie back to adoption and justification without reteaching them.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Sanctification means God has already set you apart as His, and He is making you more like Jesus.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Thank God that “holy and beloved” is already how He names His people.
2. Ask for one piece of the wardrobe — name it — to be put on this week toward a real person.
3. Ask Him to keep working in you so your effort is not a panic.

Before you stumble

Part IV ends here. Two errors: the Christian who hears “already holy” and stops fighting sin, and the Christian who hears “become holy” and lives condemned. First Corinthians 6:11 will not support either. Progress is real and uneven. Do not promise a personality transplant by next month. Do not call stubborn sin “just your wiring” if the passage names it as something to put away (Colossians 3:5–9, if you need the put-off list without making people share it).

WITH STUDENTS

Ask what team gear does to how they play. Then ask what it would mean to practice as someone already on the roster, not as someone auditioning every day.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Romans 6:11–14. Consider yourselves dead to sin and alive to God; do not let sin reign. A strong second text if the group wants the fight described more clearly.

Hope



An anchor on the seafloor, chain rising into the light. The holding place is not the sailor's mood. The flukes are in something solid, out of sight.

OPEN PART V BY SAYING

Hope, glory, and the choice of God before the world began. We end here not because election is an afterthought, but because after twenty-nine facets the room can finally hear it as assurance instead of as an argument. The Lamb wrote the book. We did not.

Before you gather

- Read Day 28, Hope, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Hebrews 6:17–20 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

What is something you are looking forward to that you are confident will happen, not just something you wish would happen?

Leader. Confidence versus wishing. The book asked how trials reveal where hope lies, and it used Ephesians 1. Do not reopen those. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Biblical hope is not “I hope so.” It is an anchor. Hebrews says it goes into the inner place, behind the curtain — into God’s own presence — because Jesus has already gone in. The chain holds when the surface does not.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Hope is the confident expectation of future good, grounded in the promises of God and secured by the finished work of Jesus Christ.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek *elpis* — confident expectation, not a wish.

MEMORY VERSE • HEBREWS 6:19

We have this as a sure and steadfast anchor of the soul, a hope that enters into the inner place behind the curtain.

Together, open the flashcard for Hope. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 · OPEN THE BIBLE · 15 MIN

Hebrews 6:17–20

Read the memory verse in its paragraph. The anchor is God's oath and Jesus' priesthood, not a technique for sad people. Then Romans 8 will take you into groaning, which the journal did not study.

So when God desired to show more convincingly to the heirs of the promise the unchangeable character of his purpose, he guaranteed it with an oath, so that by two unchangeable things, in which it is impossible for God to lie, we who have fled for refuge might have strong encouragement to hold fast to the hope set before us. We have this as a sure and steadfast anchor of the soul, a hope that enters into the inner place behind the curtain, where Jesus has gone as a forerunner on our behalf.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. What two things make the hope strong, and where does the anchor actually go?

CORE

Leader. God's promise and God's oath — He cannot lie. The anchor enters behind the curtain, where Jesus has already gone. Hope is tethered to a Person in God's presence.

2. Who is this encouragement for, according to verse 18? What had they done?

Leader. Heirs of the promise who have fled for refuge. Hope belongs to people who needed a place to run, not to people who have it together.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Read Romans 8:23–25. Paul says we hope for what we do not see, and we wait with patience. How is that different from pretending this week is fine? **CORE**

Leader. Christian hope tells the truth about groaning and still expects the adoption, the redemption of the body. It is not denial.

4. 1 Peter 1:3–4 ties living hope to the resurrection and to an inheritance that does not fade, kept in heaven. What are you hoping in that can fade, spoil, or be taken — and what cannot?

Leader. Health, money, a political outcome, a child's success, even a ministry. Name them without shaming. The inheritance is kept. They are not the anchor.

5. The chain in the drawing goes up, out of the water, where the sailor cannot see the flukes. What does it look like, practically, to “hold fast” a hope you cannot currently see?

Leader. Prayer that tells God the truth, staying with the saints, opening the promise again, refusing a smaller god. Not a smile you wear for the group.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Hope is a confident expectation of future good, anchored in God's promise and in Jesus, who has already gone in.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Thank God that He cannot lie.
2. Tell Him one groan you are not supposed to pretend away.

3. Ask for a hope strong enough to wait.

Before you stumble

Part V begins. Read the opener: the story is going somewhere. Do not use this week to explain anyone's suffering as a lesson they should have learned faster. Hebrews was written to people in danger of drifting, not to people who needed a scolding. If someone is in real despair, the anchor is Jesus the forerunner, not their ability to feel hopeful before they leave the room. Stay after if you need to.

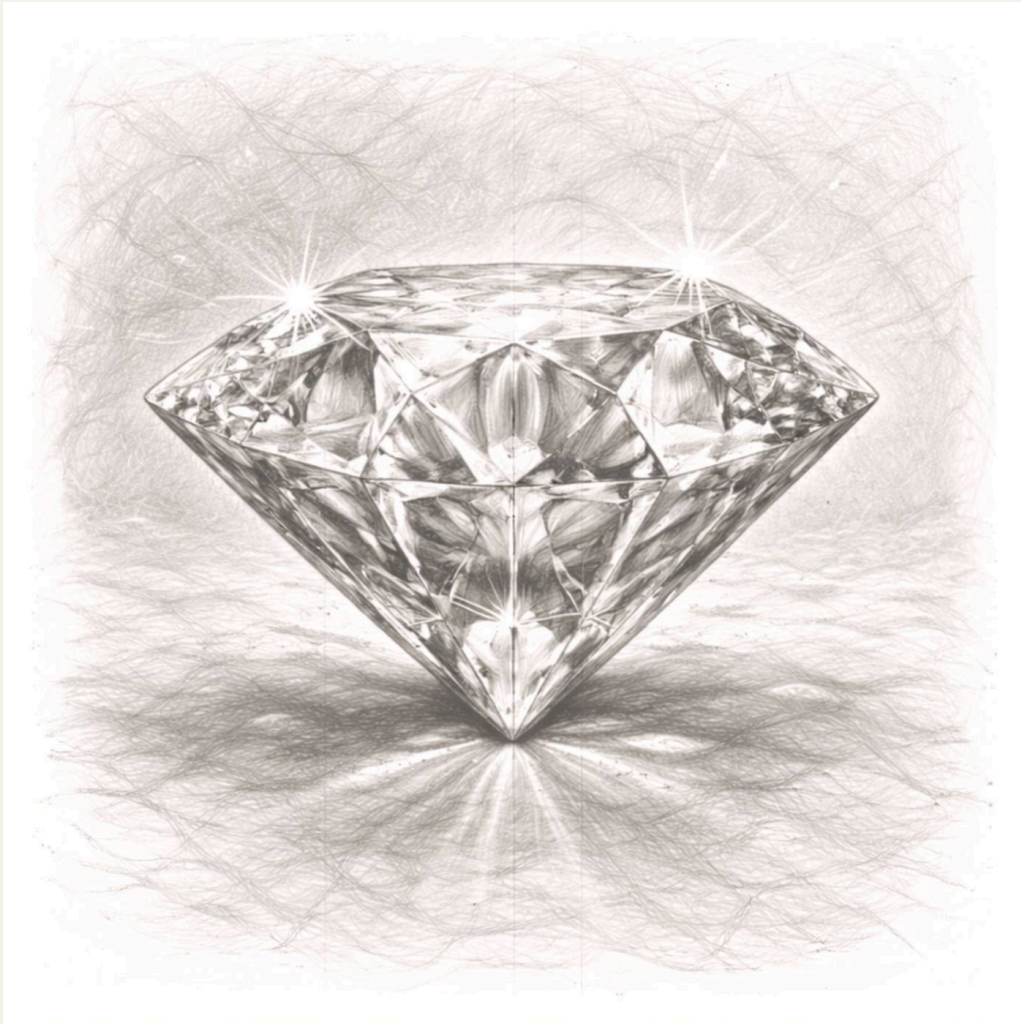
WITH STUDENTS

Ask what they mean when they say "hopefully." Then ask what Hebrews would require before that word counts as Christian hope. The bar is God's oath, not their optimism.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Romans 15:13. The God of hope fills you with joy and peace in believing, by the power of the Spirit. A benediction if the night was heavy.

Glorification



A diamond throws light it did not invent. Pressure, cut, and clarity turn a stone into something that shines. Glory, in the drawing, is reflected light.

Before you gather

- Read Day 29, Glorification, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read 1 John 3:2 and Revelation 21:3–5 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

What is something ordinary you have seen become beautiful when the light hit it right?

Leader. Light, not a list of hardships they want to escape. That list was the journal question, along with Philippians 3:20. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Glorification is not our glow-up. It is God finishing what He began, at the resurrection, when He makes His people imperishable, glorious, and like Christ. The diamond does not produce the light. It answers it.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Glorification is the wonderful moment when Jesus returns and God instantly makes every Christian completely perfect, like Jesus Himself, with no more sin, pain, weakness, or death, so we can live with Him forever in glory.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek doxa — glory, weight, honor, splendor.

MEMORY VERSE • 1 CORINTHIANS 15:42–43

So is it with the resurrection of the dead. What is sown is perishable; what is raised is imperishable. It is sown in dishonor; it is raised in glory. It is sown in weakness; it is raised in power.

Together, open the flashcard for Glorification. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 • OPEN THE BIBLE • 15 MIN

1 John 3:2 and Revelation 21:3–5

John aims the hope at seeing Jesus and becoming like Him. Revelation aims it at God dwelling with His people and making all things new. Together they keep glorification from shrinking into “a better body, same old center.”

Beloved, we are God’s children now, and what we will be has not yet appeared; but we know that when he appears we shall be like him, because we shall see him as he is. And I heard a loud voice from the throne saying, “Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man. He will dwell with them, and they will be his people, and God himself will be with them as their God. He will wipe away every tear from their eyes, and death shall be no more, neither shall there be mourning, nor crying, nor pain anymore, for the former things have passed away.” And he who was seated on the throne said, “Behold, I am making all things new.”

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. What do we already know, and what has not yet appeared? What does John say we will be, and why? CORE

Leader. We are children now. The future form has not appeared. We shall be like Him because we shall see Him. Sight of Christ is what completes the likeness.

2. In Revelation 21, what is the center of the new world — the absence of pain, or the presence of God? What happens to death, mourning, and pain, and who does it?

Leader. God with His people is the center. The wiping of tears is His act. Do not let “no more pain” replace “God himself will be with them,” even though the pain line is the one we want first.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Romans 8:30 puts glorified in the past tense, in the same chain as called and justified. Why would Paul talk about a future resurrection as if it were already decided?

CORE

Leader. Because God, who started it, does not drop the last link. Glorification is as certain as justification for those He has called. It is promise, not guess.

4. 1 Corinthians 15:42–43 contrasts perishable and imperishable, dishonor and glory, weakness and power. Which of those three contrasts do you feel most in your body or your battle with sin right now?

Leader. Let people answer simply. Then remind them the raising is God's, sudden, and complete — not a long self-improvement into glory. This is different from sanctification's slow robe.

5. 1 John 3:3 says everyone who hopes this way purifies himself, as He is pure. How does a future likeness produce present cleanliness, instead of the attitude “nothing matters until then”?

Leader. You become, in practice, what you are sure you will be. Hope of glory is fuel for holiness, not a reason to quit. Week 27 and week 29 belong together.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Glorification means that when Jesus appears, God will make every Christian perfectly like Him, body and soul, forever.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Thank God that what you will be has not appeared yet, and that He already knows.
2. Ask Him to make the hope of likeness purify one present habit.
3. Pray for someone who is weary in a perishable body.

Before you stumble

Do not describe glory in such exotic detail that you outrun the text. We know more about who we will be with than about the furniture. Do not shame sick or aging people for wanting their pain to end — Revelation includes that, under the greater promise of God with us. Glorification is for those in Christ, not a general upgrade for decent people. Say that kindly if the room widens it to everyone.

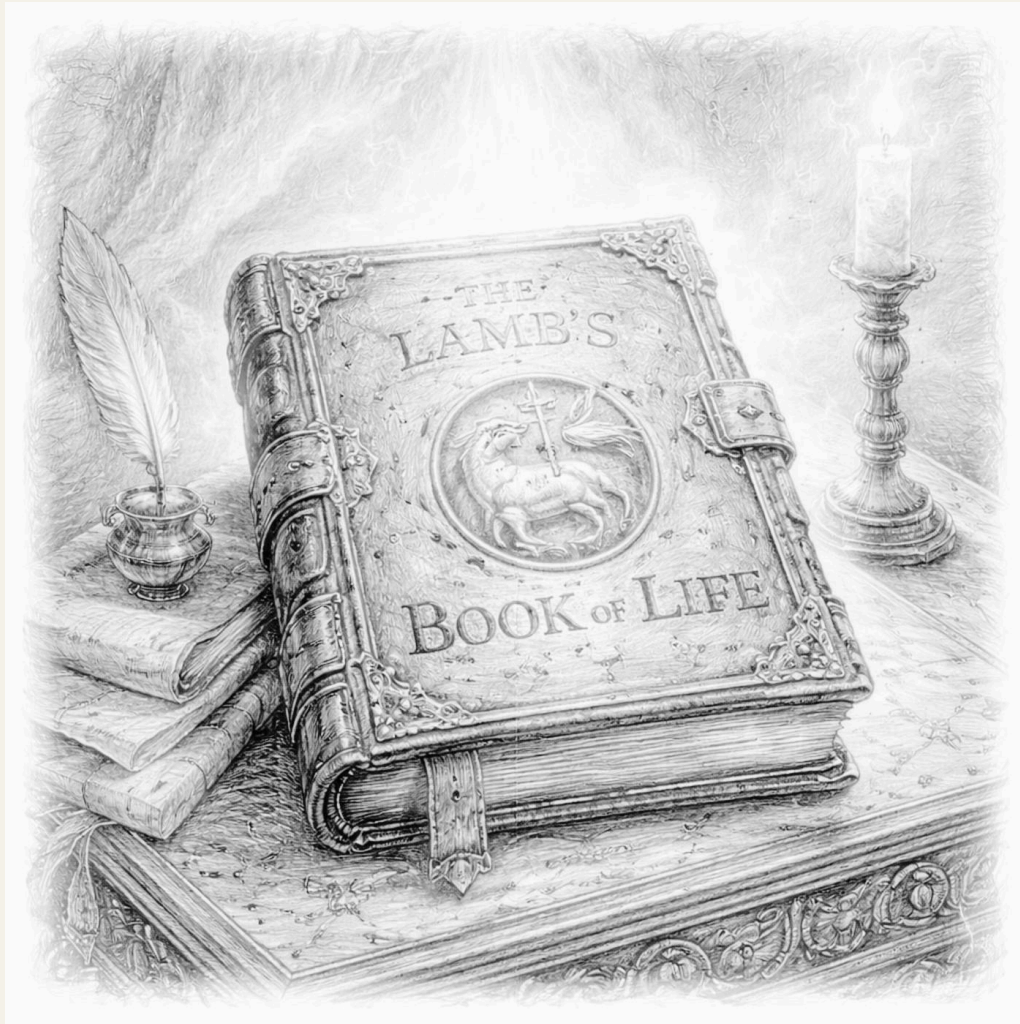
WITH STUDENTS

Ask what they think “perfect” will feel like, then read “we shall be like him, because we shall see him.” The center is Jesus, not their upgraded self. They need that re-aim.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Philippians 3:20–21, only as a closing reading if you have two minutes. They reflected on it already. Let it be a benediction: He will transform our lowly body to be like His glorious body.

Election



The Lamb's Book of Life, shut with a clasp, a quill and a candle beside it. Names in a book the readers did not write. Light falls on the cover.

Before you gather

- Read Day 30, Election, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Deuteronomy 7:6–8 and Romans 8:29–30 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

Open the room

What is a story you love where, by the end, you realize the ending was being prepared from the first chapter?

Leader. Prepared endings. The book asked about peace in storms and about names not being erased in Revelation 3:5. Leave both alone. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Election means God chose a people in Christ before the world began, out of love, to be holy. The book in the drawing is not a record of who earned a place. It is the Lamb's book. We are at the end of thirty weeks so we can see why the story was never fragile.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Election is God's choice, made before the world began, to save people through Jesus, not because they earned it or were better than others, but because of His love and mercy.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek eklegomai — to choose, to pick out, to call one's own.

MEMORY VERSE • EPHESIANS 1:3–4

Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who has blessed us in Christ with every spiritual blessing in the heavenly places, even as he chose us in him before the foundation of the world, that we should be holy and blameless before him.

Together, open the flashcard for Election. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

Deuteronomy 7:6–8 and Romans 8:29–30

Deuteronomy tells Israel they were not chosen for being impressive. Romans 8 walks the whole chain, from foreknowledge to glory, which is a way to look back over this entire study without retaking the final exam.

For you are a people holy to the LORD your God. The LORD your God has chosen you to be a people for his treasured possession, out of all the peoples who are on the face of the earth. It was not because you were more in number than any other people that the LORD set his love on you and chose you, for you were the fewest of all peoples, but it is because the LORD loves you and is keeping the oath that he swore to your fathers. For those whom he foreknew he also predestined to be conformed to the image of his Son... And those whom he predestined he also called, and those whom he called he also justified, and those whom he justified he also glorified.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. In Deuteronomy 7, what reason does God refuse for His choice, and what reason does He give? **CORE**

Leader. Not because they were numerous or impressive. Because He loves them and keeps His oath. Election empties boasting.

2. Walk Romans 8:29–30 slowly. Which words from this thirty-week study do you hear inside that chain?

Leader. Called, justified, glorified, conformed to the Son. Let them connect creation's goal, justification, sanctification's end, glorification. Do not force every word to fit. Celebrate the ones that do.

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Ephesians 1:4 says He chose us in Him — in Christ — to be holy. How does “in Christ” keep election from becoming either a reason to be proud or a reason to be paralyzed? **CORE**

Leader. Proud: “I was the impressive one.” Paralyzed: “I cannot know, so I will not come.” The answer is to look at Christ, not at a secret list. Those who come to Him find they were welcomed.

4. John 6:37: “All that the Father gives me will come to me, and whoever comes to me I will never cast out.” What does the second half do to the fear that election locks the door on someone who wants in?

Leader. The door’s rule is: the one who comes is not cast out. Election explains why anyone comes. It is not a bouncer against the willing. Say this clearly. It is the pastoral center of the night.

5. You have thirty words now. Using any five of them — no notes for a moment — how would you tell a friend what God has done in Jesus? Try it in under a minute. Clumsy is allowed.

Leader. This is the commissioning exercise. Listen, encourage, add only what they dropped if it was the cross or the response of faith. Do not grade vocabulary. If the group is large, do it in pairs.

5 • SAY IT • 5 MIN

In one sentence

Election is God’s choice, before the world began, to save a people through Jesus, out of love, not because they were better.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Bless the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, in the words of Ephesians 1 if you can.

2. Thank Him for every word in this study that has become more than a word.
3. Ask for courage to say the gospel, this week, in ordinary language. Pray for one name.

Before you stumble

This word has split rooms. Your job is not to win a system. Your job is to say what these texts say and refuse what they do not say. They do not say God is capricious or that He delights in rejecting people. They do not say we were chosen because a future faith made us attractive. They do say love, Christ, holiness, and a real human coming to Jesus. If someone is angry, let them be angry without mocking them, and give them John 6:37. If someone is proud, Deuteronomy 7 is the cure. If someone is afraid they are not chosen, the biblical test is not a feeling about eternity past. It is whether they come to Christ. Point them to Him. End the thirty weeks with praise, not with an argument. A last line you can use: the Lamb's book is His, the blood is His, the welcome is His, and it is open to all who come.

WITH STUDENTS

Skip the debate labels. Ask: "If God loved you because you were ahead of the class, what happens when you fall behind?" Then read Deuteronomy 7:7–8 in words they can hear: He did not pick you for being more. He picked you because He loves you.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Revelation 21:27. Only those written in the Lamb's book enter the city. Read it beside John 6:37 and leave both in their hands: a real book, and a real welcome.